



MOVE, PLAY & BELONG

Family-Friendly Inclusive Sport in Partner Countries

D2.1 Survey Results Report Survey and
Interview Findings Across Partner Countries



Move, Play & Belong:
Inclusive Family Sports

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1. Executive Summary

Physical activity contributes to physical health, mental well-being, social development and quality of life across the life course. The World Health Organization recommends regular moderate-to-vigorous physical activity for children, adolescents and adults, while also emphasising that people living with disability should be supported to participate according to their abilities and circumstances (World Health Organization, 2020). Nevertheless, participation remains uneven. The 2022 Eurobarometer found that 45 % of Europeans never exercised or participated in physical activity, with lack of time reported as the most common barrier (European Commission, 2022).

Access to organised sport is shaped by more than individual motivation. A systematic review of children's physical activity found a particularly consistent relationship between socioeconomic circumstances and participation in organised physical activity: children from households with greater income, education and occupational resources were generally more likely to participate in structured sport (Ziegeldorf et al., 2024). Fees are part of this inequality, but families may also require transport, equipment, suitable schedules, childcare and the time and confidence needed to negotiate registration and club systems.

The family is therefore an important part of the participation environment. Parents and carers may provide encouragement, transport, payment, equipment, interpretation and emotional support. They may also decide whether an activity is sufficiently safe, affordable and suitable for the household. Qualitative research on family-based physical activity programmes shows that engagement is influenced by children's interests, social relationships, financial constraints, available resources and whether coaches create an inclusive and enjoyable environment (Brennan et al., 2025). This makes family-focused analysis particularly important: a technically available activity may remain unusable if its organisation does not reflect the realities of family life.

Research concerning children with disabilities similarly identifies barriers at personal, interpersonal, organisational and environmental levels. These include inadequate facilities, transport difficulties, cost, limited staff capacity, negative attitudes and insufficient information. Facilitators include skilled staff, family and peer support, accessible facilities, proximity and suitable opportunities (Shields, Synnot and Barr, 2012). Evidence concerning migrant participation also cautions against assuming that sport automatically produces inclusion. Sport can create connections and belonging, but it can also reproduce exclusion when families are expected to understand unfamiliar language, procedures and cultural norms without organisational adaptation (Smith, Spaaij and McDonald, 2019).

Against this background, Move, Play & Belong examines how socially at-risk families experience family-friendly and inclusive sport in Estonia, Italy, Latvia, Greece and Spain. The report does not seek to test a single explanation for non-participation. Instead, it considers the complete participation journey: how families learn about an

opportunity, assess its cost and suitability, organise attendance, reach the venue, experience the social environment and decide whether continued participation is realistic.

This D2.1 Survey Results Report draws on 208 survey responses and 25 qualitative interviews collected by project partners. It reports the participation barriers, family circumstances, access conditions and opportunities for intervention identified through the survey and interview evidence. Across the five samples, 116 respondents, or 55.8 %, reported that their family had participated in a relevant activity during the previous 12 months. Participation was highest in Italy at 62.8 % and lowest in Greece at 46.3 %. The samples are descriptive rather than nationally representative. However, the convergence between the closed questions, Q15 open responses and interviews provide a detailed account of trends, challenges and possible intervention areas for the next stage of project development.

Headline Results

Country	Survey	Participation	Leading Constraint	Leading Offer	Leading Q15 Theme
Estonia	43	25 (58.1%)	Cost (76.7%)	Weekly sessions (53.5%)	Information (62.8%)
Italy	43	27 (62.8%)	Lack of family offers (37.2%)	Parent-child (44.2%)	Affordability (46.7%)
Latvia	41	22 (53.7%)	Unsuitable times (56.1%)	Weekend and parent-child (48.8%)	Access, cost and welcome (26.8%)
Greece	41	19 (46.3%)	Lack of information (51.2%)	One-day event (51.2%)	Welcome and trust (45.5%)
Spain	40	23 (57.5%)	Lack of information (45.0%)	One-day event (75.0%)	Affordability (45.5%)

What the Evidence Shows

- There is no single universal constraint. Cost dominates in Estonia, timing in Latvia, information in Greece and Spain, and the shortage of suitable family offers in Italy.
- Affordability still matters everywhere, but families judge value as well as price. Across all countries, 38.9% said an acceptable fee depends on what is included; 37.5% selected free activities or no more than €5 per person.

- Local delivery is the strongest practical preference. Nearly two thirds of respondents selected activities closer to home, while schools and community centres were the next most common venue preference.
- Families need a clear progression route from a first experience to regular participation. Local club information, a named contact, familiar coaches or groups and low-risk trial sessions repeatedly ranked highly.
- A welcoming environment is a basic condition rather than an optional enhancement. Friendly staff, freedom from discrimination, clear safeguarding and knowing whom to contact were rated important by more than nine in ten respondents in the four countries with comparable scales.
- Communication must be tailored to local habits. Schools are especially important in Latvia and Greece; peer networks and coaches stand out in Estonia; municipalities and WhatsApp matter in Italy; and Spain relies strongly on WhatsApp, flyers and email rather than social media alone.
- The qualitative evidence adds a time dimension: families want regularity, predictable schedules, dignity, personal trust and a visible next step after the first event.

SCOPE OF THIS REPORT: This report is confined to the D2.1 survey and interview evidence. It identifies trends, challenges and opportunities for intervention at country and cross-country level, based on the experiences reported by participating families.

2. Introduction

Family-friendly sport offers are shaped by household and community realities as much as by individual interest. Parents and carers assess cost, safety and suitability; siblings influence how family time is organised; and transport, information, language, disability access and trust can determine whether an apparently open activity is usable in practice. The existence of a club or event is therefore only one part of access. Move, Play & Belong: Inclusive Family Sports (MPB), Erasmus+ Sport project 101245086, responds to financial, cultural and structural constraints that can limit access to sport and physical activity for socially at-risk families. For this project, the term describes families facing social, economic, health-related or environmental disadvantages that restrict regular participation and may affect physical, mental or social well-being.

This report examines family perspectives collected in Estonia, Italy, Latvia, Greece and Spain. It analyses recent participation, constraints, preferred formats, communication, accessibility, welcome and safety, continuity and feedback. The Q15 open responses and interviews add detail about how these issues interact in everyday family life. The purpose of this D2.1 report is to compile and analyse the primary evidence provided by families. Country findings are presented separately before the five samples are compared, allowing common patterns and important differences to remain visible.

Survey and Interview Analytical Framework

The analytical framework follows the structure of the questionnaire and interview guide. It examines the full participation journey through which a family hears about an activity, decides whether it is affordable and practical, reaches the venue, feels safe and welcome, takes part and identifies a possible next step.

Family-Centred Participation

Family members are not only spectators or logistical support. They may provide transport, interpretation, care, encouragement and decision-making, while their own participation can make an activity more practical and meaningful. Family-centred provision therefore considers parents, carers, children, siblings and wider family networks when designing the offer.

Social Inclusion and Belonging

Formal eligibility does not guarantee equal access. Inclusion requires understandable information, dignity, freedom from discrimination, safe relationships and meaningful participation. A family may technically be allowed to attend while still feeling that the setting was not designed with its circumstances, language, culture or support needs in mind.

Practical Access Conditions

Constraints operate at connected levels. Individual confidence and previous experience interact with family time, childcare and finance; organisational fees, schedules, registration and staff skills; and community transport, local networks and

suitable facilities. An activity that is free of charge may still be inaccessible if transport, equipment or timing is unworkable.

Inclusive Sport Design

Inclusive design lowers the threshold for first participation, offers different ways to take part and provides a visible route into continued involvement. One-day events, family festivals and taster sessions can be effective entry points, but their long-term value depends on progression into recurring activity, a familiar group, a local club or another dependable form of support.

3. Methodology

Research Design

The study used a mixed-methods descriptive design comprising a structured survey, an open-text survey question and semi-structured family interviews. The closed survey questions establish the distribution of reported barriers, preferences and participation conditions within each partner sample. Q15 and the interviews explain how these conditions are experienced and why apparently separate barriers often operate together.

The evidence base comprises 208 survey responses and 25 interviews: 43 surveys and 5 interviews from Estonia; 43 and 5 from Italy; 41 and 5 from Latvia; 41 and 5 from Greece; and 40 and 5 from Spain. There were 180 substantive Q15 responses. All five country samples used the same core questionnaire and interview framework.

Country	Survey Responses	Substantive Q15 Responses	Interviews
Estonia	43	43	5
Italy	43	30	5
Latvia	41	41	5
Greece	41	33	5
Spain	40	33	5
Total	208	180	25

Survey Procedure and Instrument

National project partners collected survey responses in their respective contexts using the shared MPB family-focused questionnaire. The target population was parents, carers, guardians and family members from disadvantaged, migrant and low-income households, including families containing people with disabilities or long-term support needs. The questionnaire covered recent participation; barriers; affordability and cost transparency; preferred formats; continuity after initial events; timing; transport; communication; language and cultural inclusion; disability access; welcome and safety; family roles; feedback preferences; and optional background characteristics. Closed questions included single-choice, multi-select and Likert-scale formats. Q15 invited respondents to explain, in their own words, the most important consideration for enabling disadvantaged, migrant and low-income families to join and continue participating. Participation was voluntary, and the instrument informed respondents that answers would be treated anonymously and confidentially and analysed in summary form. The present report does not reproduce names or direct personal identifiers. Open-text excerpts have been attributed only to anonymised country and response numbers.

Interview Procedure

The interviews constituted a distinct qualitative strand rather than an extension of the closed survey. Five selected families were interviewed in each country using a common semi-structured guide. The guide began with three informal questions intended to establish rapport and encourage participants to describe family activity in their own terms. The substantive discussion then examined interpersonal influences, including family members, friends, coaches and community organisations; intrapersonal factors such as confidence, trust, safety, motivation, language and belonging; structural conditions including cost, transport, timing, childcare, accessibility, registration and information; continuity after a first event; and ways in which organisations could make family sport more accessible. A final open question allowed participants to raise matters not captured by the preceding prompts.

The semi-structured format allowed interviewers to ask follow-up questions and explore examples. The submitted material varied in form: some country files contained near-verbatim dialogue, while others contained translated or summarised accounts. Quotations in this report reproduce the English wording supplied in the partner datasets, with minor omissions for length. This variation means that comparisons should focus on meaning and thematic convergence rather than the number or length of statements recorded in each country.

Quantitative Analysis

All coded answers were decoded into descriptive labels. Each respondent was retained once in the principal response table. For multi-select questions, every selected option was retained as a separate record, ensuring that no response was lost. Percentages for these questions represent the proportion of respondents selecting an option and consequently do not sum to 100 %.

Qualitative Analysis

Q15 responses were coded using eight principal themes: affordability; information and communication; timing; transport and local access; welcome and trust; accessibility and adaptation; continuity; and family participation. An additional “other or unclear” category was used where necessary. Interview answers were organised through a framework analysis reflecting the interview guide while allowing additional issues to emerge. The framework covered affordability; information and registration; transport; timing; welcome and belonging; inclusive coaching; disability and facility access; continuity; family participation; trusted networks; and equipment or practical support. A response or interview could receive more than one code when it addressed several issues.

Interview theme counts represent the number of interviews in which a theme appeared at least once, rather than the number of times it was repeated. This avoids giving greater numerical weight to longer interviews. Quotations were selected

because they explain a mechanism or illuminate a common theme; they should not be interpreted as statistically representative statements.

Integration Of Evidence

The survey, Q15 and interview findings were triangulated. Convergence occurs where a closed-question result is reinforced by open-text and interview evidence. Divergence was also retained. For example, most of a national sample may report no accessibility requirement while interview participants with disability-related needs describe substantial barriers. Such divergence is analytically important because it shows how minority needs can disappear within an overall average.

Interpretation And Limitations

The findings are described as evidence from five partner samples rather than population estimates because the source material does not document a national probability-sampling frame, random selection or known selection probability for respondents. Country sample sizes are small, recruitment was conducted through project-partner contexts, and country response rates are not available. Families already connected to partner organisations or interested in sport may therefore be more likely to be represented.

With approximately 40 respondents per country, one response changes a national percentage by roughly 2.3 to 2.5 percentage points. In an interview sample of five, one family represents 20 %. Differences between countries may reflect recruitment, sample composition, missing background data, translation and local implementation as well as genuine contextual differences. The results should consequently not be used to rank national populations.

This limitation does not make the findings uninformative. The data provide direct evidence about the participating families, while convergence across closed questions, Q15 and interviews strengthens confidence that the identified issues are meaningful within these samples. Their principal value is explanatory: they identify where participation becomes difficult, how barriers combine and what families consider necessary for an opportunity to be usable.

4. Country Findings

The five partner samples share a common questionnaire and interview structure, but each country shows a different combination of barriers and enabling conditions. The following sections present each country first, as requested by project partners, before the evidence is synthesized across countries.

4.1 Estonia

The Estonia sample contains 43 survey responses and five interviews. Participation was above the five-country average, but the data reveal a concentrated affordability problem alongside substantial language and accessibility needs in specific subgroups.

Indicator	Result	Interpretation
Participation	25 of 43 (58.1%)	A majority had participated during the previous year
Financial difficulty	33 of 43 (76.7%)	The highest recorded rate among countries with comparable data
Migrant or minority background	19 of 43 (44.2%)	Language support is a material design requirement
Disability or support need	12 of 43 (27.9%)	Accessibility results should be read by subgroup

Constraints and Participation Profile

Cost was selected by 33 respondents, or 76.7%, more than twice the next most common barrier. Every respondent reporting financial difficulty selected cost, making affordability the clearest point of exclusion. Transport or distance affected 16 respondents, while unsuitable times and feeling unwelcome were also prominent. Families largely expected a low entry price: 65.1% selected free activities or €1 to €5 per person, and 90.7% considered full cost information important or very important.



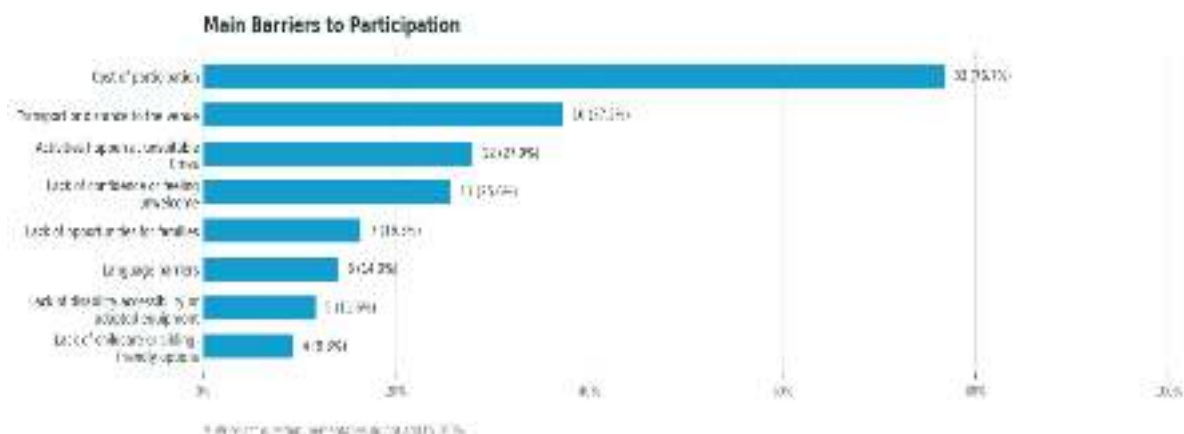


Figure 4.1.1. Estonia participation profile and main barriers
 Source: Estonia survey, n = 43. Barrier percentages are multi-select.

Affordability and Cost Transparency

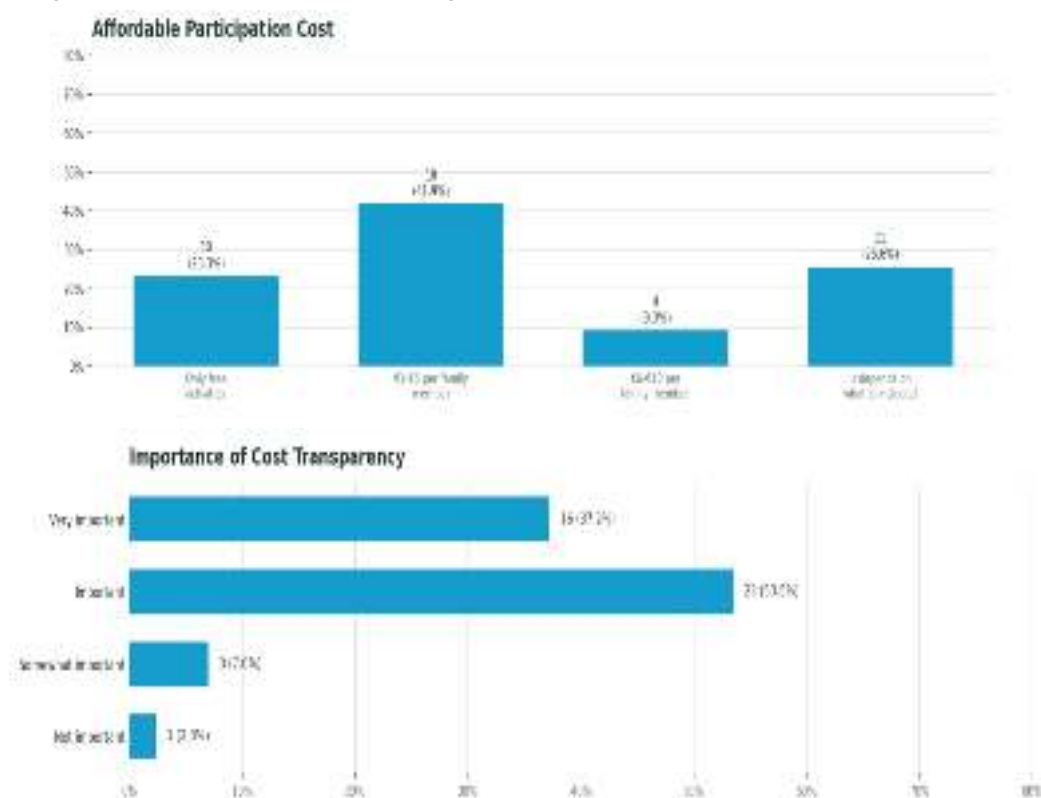


Figure 4.1.2. Estonia affordability and cost transparency
 Source: Estonia survey, n = 43.

The Estonia results reveal an important distinction between participation and ease of access. Although 58.1% had participated during the previous year, 76.7% reported financial difficulty and the same proportion selected cost as a barrier. Participation therefore should not be interpreted as evidence that barriers have been resolved. Some families appear to be participating despite substantial financial pressure.

Cost was followed by transport or distance at 37.2%, unsuitable timing at 27.9% and feeling unwelcome at 25.6%. These results suggest cumulative exclusion: the family

must be able to afford the activity, reach it, fit it around household responsibilities and feel comfortable asking for assistance. The affordability chart supports this interpretation. Altogether, 65.1% selected free activity or no more than €5 per family member, while 90.7% considered full cost information important or very important.

The interviews show why transparency matters. One participant explained: “The advertised price is often only the beginning. Then there are shoes, a shirt, a tournament, transport, maybe food”. The issue is therefore not simply the advertised fee but the financial uncertainty surrounding participation. The same participant summarised the relational dimension succinctly: “The biggest thing is dignity. Cheap does not have to feel like charity.”

Offer Design and Continuity

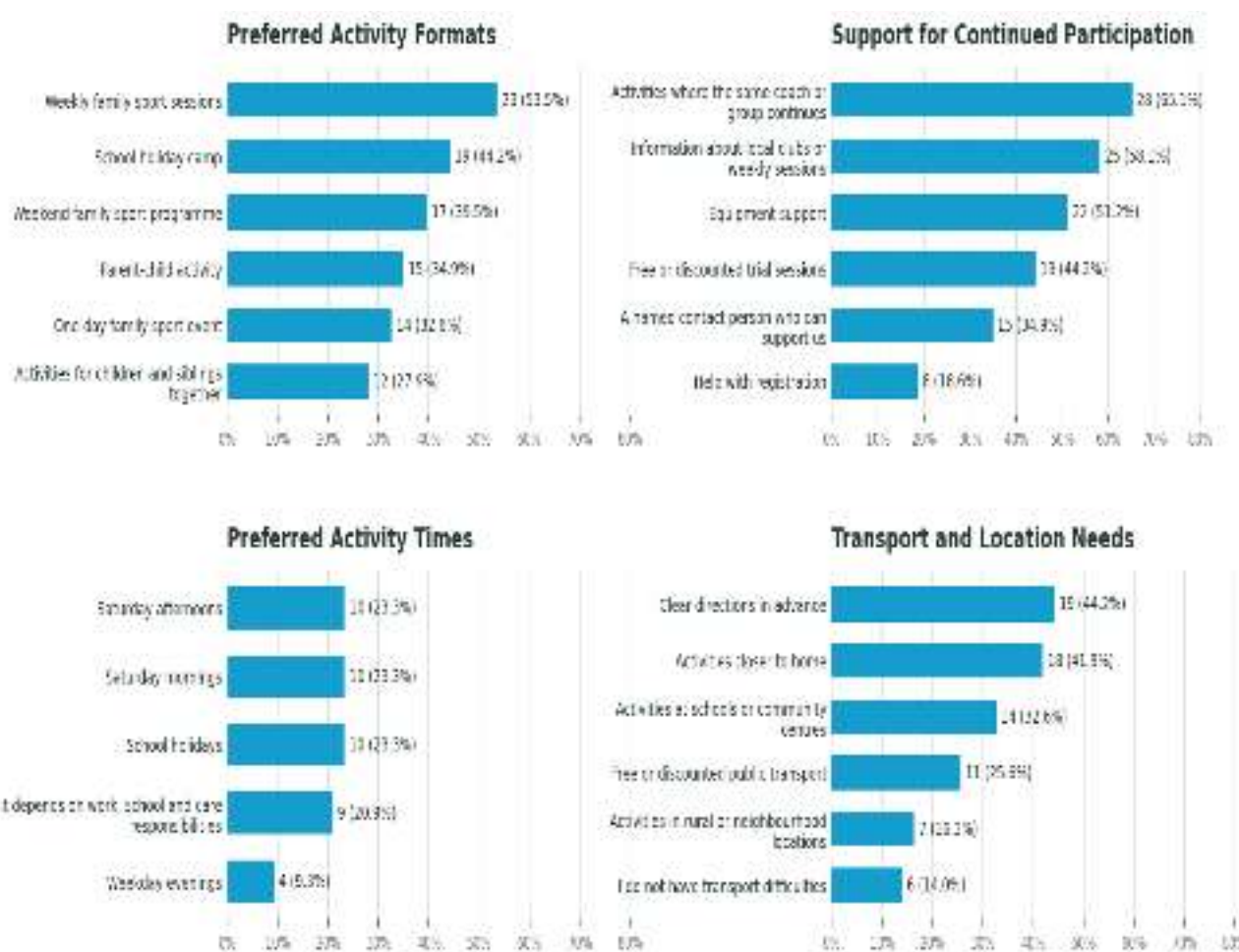


Figure 4.1.3. Estonia preferred formats and continuation support

Source: Estonia survey, $n = 43$. Both questions allowed up to three selections.

Estonia's preference for weekly sessions, selected by 53.5%, distinguishes it from countries favouring introductory events. School-holiday camps, weekend programmes and parent-child activities also attracted substantial interest, indicating that recurring provision should still offer several routes of entry. Continuity results reinforce this pattern. The same coach or group was selected by 65.1%, local club or weekly-session information by 58.1% and equipment support by 51.2%.

Families are not only asking for more events. They are asking for a stable relationship, practical assistance and a recognisable next step.

Timing preferences were divided across Saturday mornings, Saturday afternoons and school holidays. A further 20.9% said timing depended on work, school and care. This distribution suggests that no single slot will serve every household. Predictability and choice are more important than identifying one supposedly ideal time.

An interview with a rural family illustrates this interaction: “We do not need a spectacular programme. We need something close enough that saying yes does not require a family transport operation”. A Q15 respondent expressed the same priority: “Regular sessions close to home would matter more to us than occasional large events”

Information Inclusion and Welcome

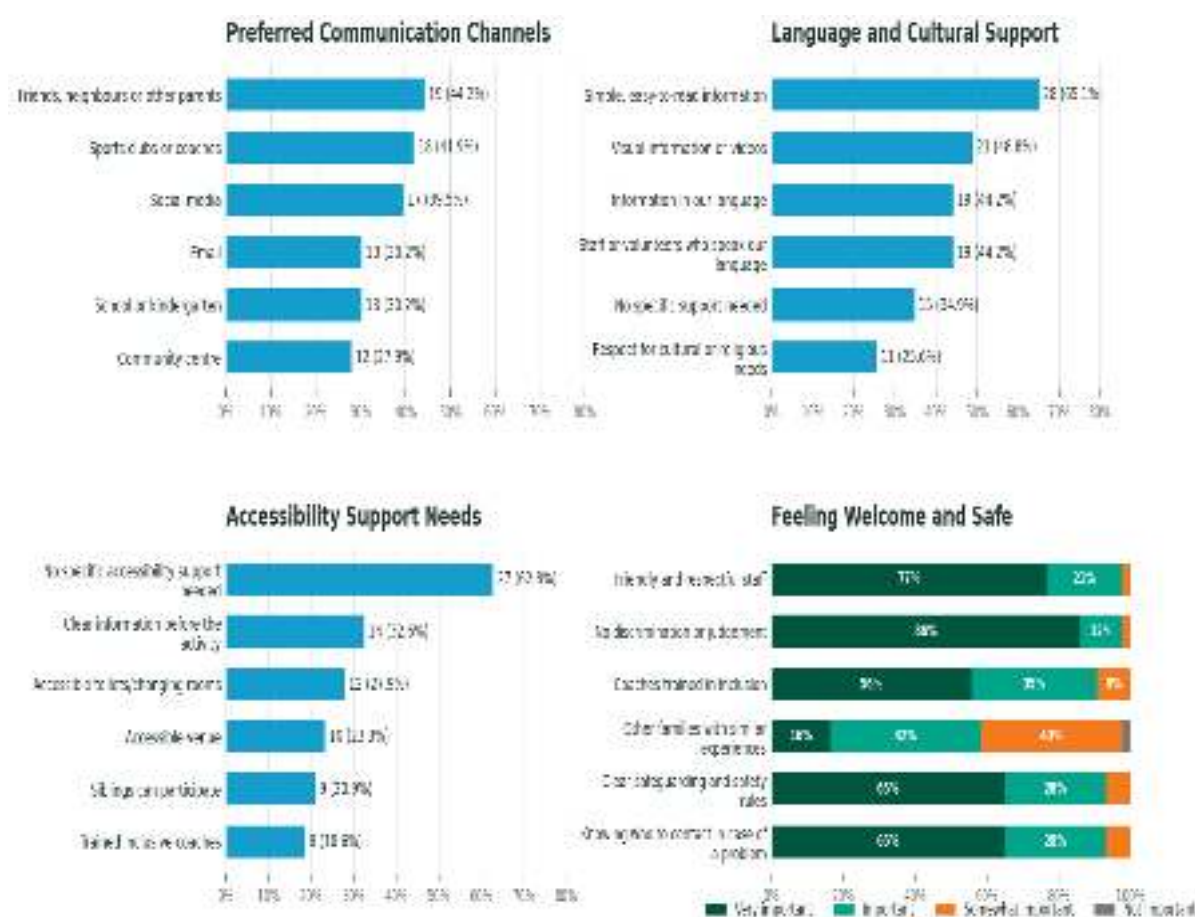


Figure 4.1.4 Estonia communication language and accessibility priorities

Source: Estonia survey, $n = 43$. Accessibility subgroup results are described in the text.

Simple information was selected by 65.1%, visual information by 48.8%, and both information in the family's language and language-speaking staff by 44.2%. The result becomes more pronounced within the migrant or minority subgroup: all 19 respondents selected own-language information, staff speaking their language and

simple information. The qualitative evidence shows that language affects confidence as well as comprehension. One participant stated: “Language difficulty is not the same as lack of ability. Sometimes the parent standing quietly at the door understands exactly what the child needs; they just need another minute to find the words”. Language support should therefore be understood as a means of enabling equal participation rather than treating migrant families as a separate audience.

Accessibility demonstrates the danger of relying only on sample averages. Although 62.8% selected no specific accessibility support, the 12 respondents reporting a disability or support need identified accessible toilets, accessible venues, advance information and trained coaches as major requirements. One interview participant explained: “Accessibility for us is not mainly a ramp. It is group size, noise, changing rooms, a place to withdraw, a coach who understands sensory overload”.

The Q12 results support this relational interpretation. Friendly staff and freedom from discrimination were important or very important to 97.7%, compared with 58.1% for being alongside families with similar experiences. Families appear to prioritise respectful treatment and competent support over being grouped exclusively with people perceived as similar.

Family Perspectives from Q15 and Interviews

The Estonia open-text responses show that families do not experience affordability, communication, timing, transport and inclusion as separate issues. Information and communication appeared in 27 of the 43 Q15 responses, affordability in 26, welcome and trust in 22, timing in 16, accessibility or adaptation in 14, continuity in 14 and transport or local access in 12. The large number of responses carrying several themes indicates that participation often depends on an entire package of conditions being workable at the same time.

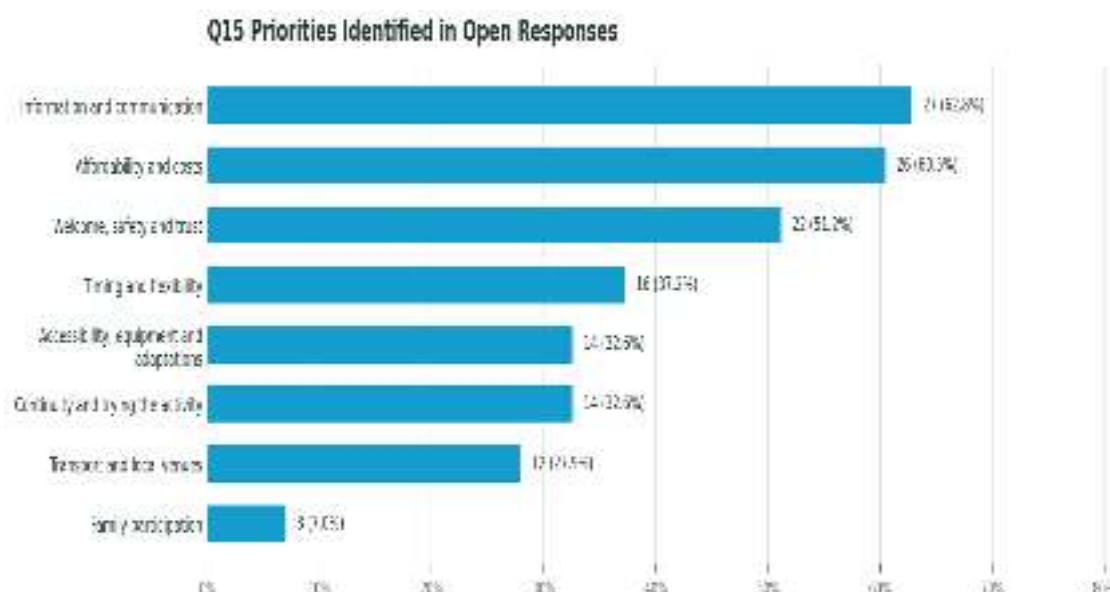


Figure 4.1.5 Estonia Q15 themes and anonymised perspectives

Source: 43 substantive Q15 responses. Responses may carry several themes.

Several Q15 responses described the need to reduce the financial risk of trying an activity. One respondent asked for “free trial sessions followed by a low monthly fee” so that the family could decide whether the activity was suitable before making a longer commitment. The same respondent combined this with adapted coaching, school-holiday provision and regular sessions close to home, adding that “regular sessions close to home would matter more to us than occasional large events” (E-Q15-29). This is important because it shows that families are not necessarily seeking free one-off experiences. They are seeking an affordable and realistic route into sustained participation.

Other responses connected inclusion with what families know before leaving home. One respondent wrote that families need to know that “a child who needs extra support will still be genuinely included”, while also requesting flexible timing, local venues and visual examples of a normal session (E-Q15-21). Another asked for “clear information and no assumption that families already know how clubs work”, an easy first session and advance information about accessible toilets and changing rooms (E-Q15-34). These comments show that information reduces several forms of uncertainty simultaneously: financial uncertainty, uncertainty about expected behavior and clothing, and uncertainty about whether a child’s support needs will be accepted.

Themes Across Interviews

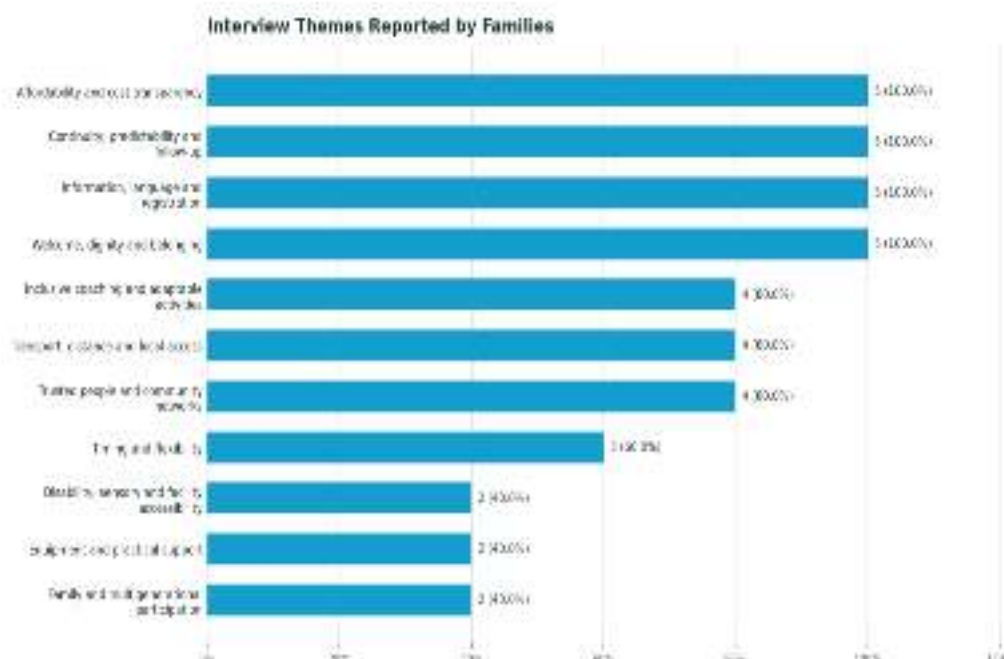


Figure 4.1.6 Estonia interview themes

Source: Five interviews. Each interview may carry several themes.

The five interviews provide much richer accounts of how these barriers operate in everyday life. The first interview concerned a single-parent household. The participant described the advertised fee as only the beginning of the cost: **“Then there are shoes, a shirt, a tournament, transport, maybe food. With two children I need to know the real amount before I say yes.”**

The same participant explained that a session at 16:30 might suit the club but be impossible for a working parent. Registration involving several forms created another burden. What the family wanted after a try-out was very practical: **“the next two or three dates, the real monthly price and one person I can message” (E-INT1)**. This illustrates why cost transparency, scheduling and a named contact cannot be considered separately. Families need sufficient information to determine whether an enjoyable first experience can become a manageable routine.

This interview also introduced dignity as a central analytical theme. The participant stated: **“The biggest thing is dignity. Cheap does not have to feel like charity. If I can pay what I can afford, understand the rules and my children are treated like everyone else, we are very likely to come back.”** This perspective adds an important qualification to financial assistance. Support that requires families to disclose extensive personal information or marks them publicly as recipients may reduce rather than strengthen belonging. The issue is not simply whether a discount exists, but whether families can use it without humiliation or judgement.

The second interview described the experiences of a migrant family. Trust was transferred through people rather than through formal advertising: **“A teacher, neighbour or another Ukrainian parent saying ‘I know this coach, it is fine’ is much more convincing than a perfect poster” (E-INT2)**. The family’s daughter

joined an activity because another parent accompanied them on the first visit. Demonstrations and visual communication helped more than lengthy instructions, while patient responses to language mistakes signalled whether the family belonged.

The participant cautioned against interpreting limited language confidence as limited understanding: **“Please remember that language difficulty is not the same as lack of ability. Sometimes the parent standing quietly at the door understands exactly what the child needs; they just need another minute to find the words.”** The family did not want a separate migrant activity. Instead, it wanted to be invited into the same activity with simpler instructions, photos of the venue, a short explanatory video and a contact person comfortable with imperfect language. A short WhatsApp message after the first session could provide the date, price and required equipment. Continuity with the same coach and children also mattered because **“we stop when every week feels like starting from zero with new people and new instructions” (E-INT2).**

The third interview demonstrates the specific character of rural exclusion. This family was already active outdoors and did not lack confidence or motivation. Its difficulty concerned distance, fuel, winter travel, unsuitable bus schedules and the time required to coordinate work and children. The participant explained: **“We do not need a spectacular programme. We need something close enough that saying yes does not require a family transport operation.”** The family preferred a predictable rhythm such as every second Saturday over irregular dates. It proposed using school gyms, community buildings and outdoor areas in smaller settlements, with coaches travelling between communities rather than expecting every family to travel to a central venue. This is a distinctive contribution of the interviews: accessibility may require moving the provision, not merely helping families reach it.

The fourth interview focused on sensory and disability inclusion. The participant described a coach who asked the child whether he wanted the activity to be shown, explained or observed first. That small choice transformed the session. By contrast, staff who said an activity was inclusive but did not know how to respond when a child required a break created anxiety for the whole family.

The participant explained: **“Accessibility for us is not mainly a ramp. It is group size, noise, changing rooms, a place to withdraw, a coach who understands sensory overload and permission for a parent or assistant to stay close.”** Advance information about the room, number of participants, music and arrangements for breaks helped the family decide whether to attend. The participant also criticised forms containing only a yes-or-no “special needs” box, preferring an opportunity to explain what support actually works. Continuity meant the same room, coach and general sequence, with changes communicated beforehand. The family’s definition of success was not completing every exercise; it was being able to **“adapt without apologising” and leave wanting to return (E-INT4).**

The fifth interview provided a multigenerational perspective. Teenagers, adults and grandparents had different confidence levels and schedules. The family avoided activities that felt like disguised competitions because less-confident members withdrew. At one previous event, all instructions were directed towards children and **“the parents became coat racks. We did not return” (E-INT5)**. In contrast, community-centre and school settings felt familiar and less intimidating.

This family wanted a family-level price because separate fees for five people made a simple afternoon expensive. It also needed seating, accessible toilets and information about intensity. Rather than weekly training, it preferred a regular monthly rhythm with familiar faces. The participant concluded that some of the most valuable moments occurred after the activity, when grandparents spoke to one another while children continued playing: **“That is when an event starts becoming a community.”**

Taken together, the Estonia interviews reveal five different but connected experiences: single-parent financial and scheduling pressure; migrant-language navigation; rural distance; sensory inclusion; and multigenerational participation. Their convergence around transparent costs, familiar people, predictable follow-up and dignified treatment gives the qualitative evidence substantial analytical weight. At the same time, their differences demonstrate why one standard form of support would be insufficient.

Estonia's Conclusion

Estonia's findings show that a relatively high participation rate can coexist with severe participation pressure. Families may already be making considerable financial, logistical and emotional efforts to remain involved. Cost is the most visible constraint, but the qualitative evidence reveals that affordability includes hidden charges, equipment, food, transport, sibling fees and the risk of paying for something that later proves incompatible with work or care responsibilities. Financial support therefore affects not only whether a family can pay, but whether it can plan confidently and participate without feeling marked as a charitable case.

The country evidence also demonstrates that inclusion has different practical meanings for different families. For a migrant family, it may involve visual information, patient communication and a trusted person accompanying the first visit. For a rural family, it may mean bringing coaching to the local school gym. For a neurodiverse child, it may mean knowing the room, noise level and group size and having permission to observe or take a break. For a multigenerational family, it may mean a non-competitive activity, seating and a family-level fee. Across these experiences, the common requirement is a predictable and respectful pathway: families need to understand the offer, know the real cost, meet a familiar person, see how their circumstances will be accommodated and know what can happen after the first session.

4.2 Italy

The Italy sample contains 43 survey responses and five interviews.

Indicator	Result	Interpretation
Participation	27 of 43 (62.8%)	The highest participation rate in the five samples
Financial difficulty	12 of 39 (30.8%)	Use subgroup results cautiously because of small numbers
Migrant or minority background	7 of 39 (17.9%)	Use subgroup results cautiously because of small numbers
Disability or support need	3 of 39 (7.7%)	Too small for detailed subgroup reporting

Constraints and Participation Profile

Italy recorded the highest participation rate, at 62.8%, yet its leading barrier was the lack of opportunities designed for families, selected by 37.2%. Cost followed at 34.9% and unsuitable timing at 30.2%. This indicates that existing participation may be centred on children's individual or competitive sport rather than activities that families can experience together.



Figure 4.2.1 Italy participation profile and main barriers

Source: Italy survey, n = 43. Barrier percentages are multi-select.

Affordability and Cost Transparency

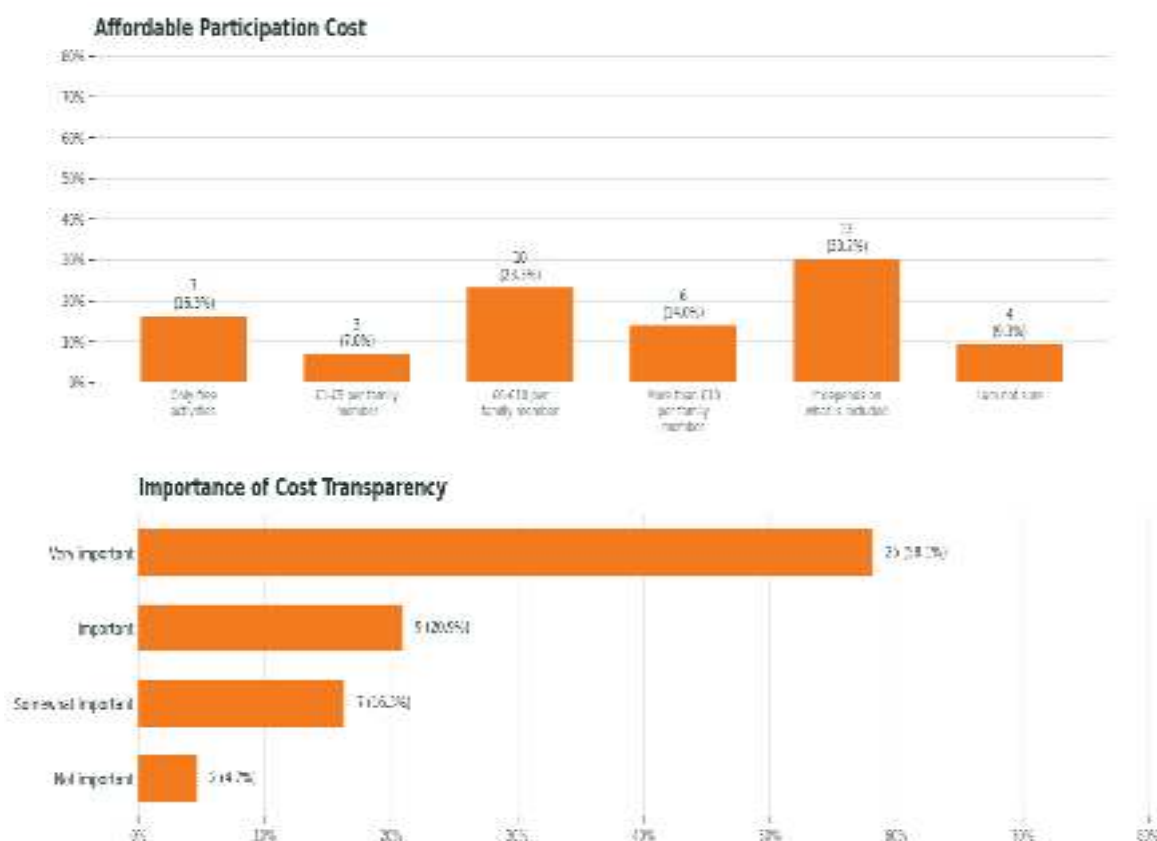


Figure 4.2.2 Italy affordability and cost transparency

Source: Italy survey, $n = 43$.

The relationship between cost and disadvantage is clearer within the financial-difficulty subgroup, where 66.7% selected cost and 50.0% selected the shortage of family opportunities. Italy's affordability answers were more varied than Estonia's, but 30.2% said the acceptable amount depended on what was included. Cost transparency was important or very important to 79.1%. Families appear prepared to consider different price levels when the value, duration, equipment and complete financial commitment are clear.

Offer Design and Continuity

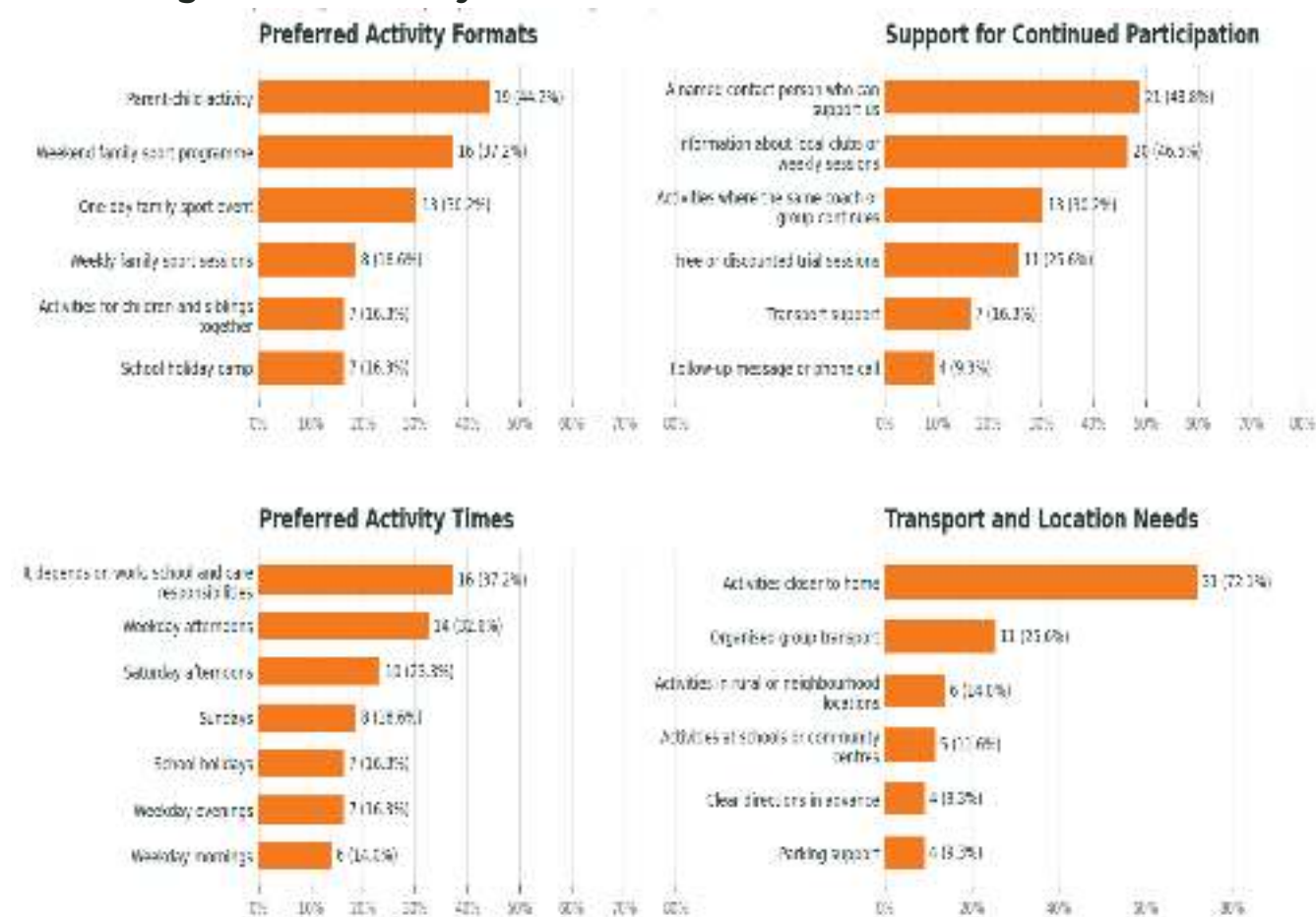


Figure 4.2.3 Italy preferred formats and continuation support

Source: Italy survey, $n = 43$. Both questions allowed up to three selections.

Parent-child activities led programme preferences at 44.2%, followed by weekend programmes at 37.2%. The named contact person was the leading continuation support, at 48.8%, closely followed by information about local clubs or weekly sessions. The combined result suggests that Italy's participation gap concerns both programme content and navigation: families want activities designed for shared participation and somebody who can help them understand what happens next.

Timing depended on work, school and care for 37.2%, and 72.1% wanted activities closer to home. These figures should be read alongside childcare and sibling-friendly barriers. A convenient activity is one that reduces the number of separate journeys and arrangements a family must organise.

A shift-working participant explained that "everything is designed around people with standard office hours", while missed sessions could not always be made up. This account shows that rigidity can turn a temporary scheduling problem into eventual withdrawal.

Information Inclusion and Welcome

Municipal channels, social media and WhatsApp each reached 34.9%, with clubs and coaches following at 27.9%. No single channel dominates, so partners should repeat consistent information across civic, digital and sport networks. The language and accessibility results are less concentrated than in Estonia or Greece, but simple information, accessible venues and accessible toilets remain relevant.

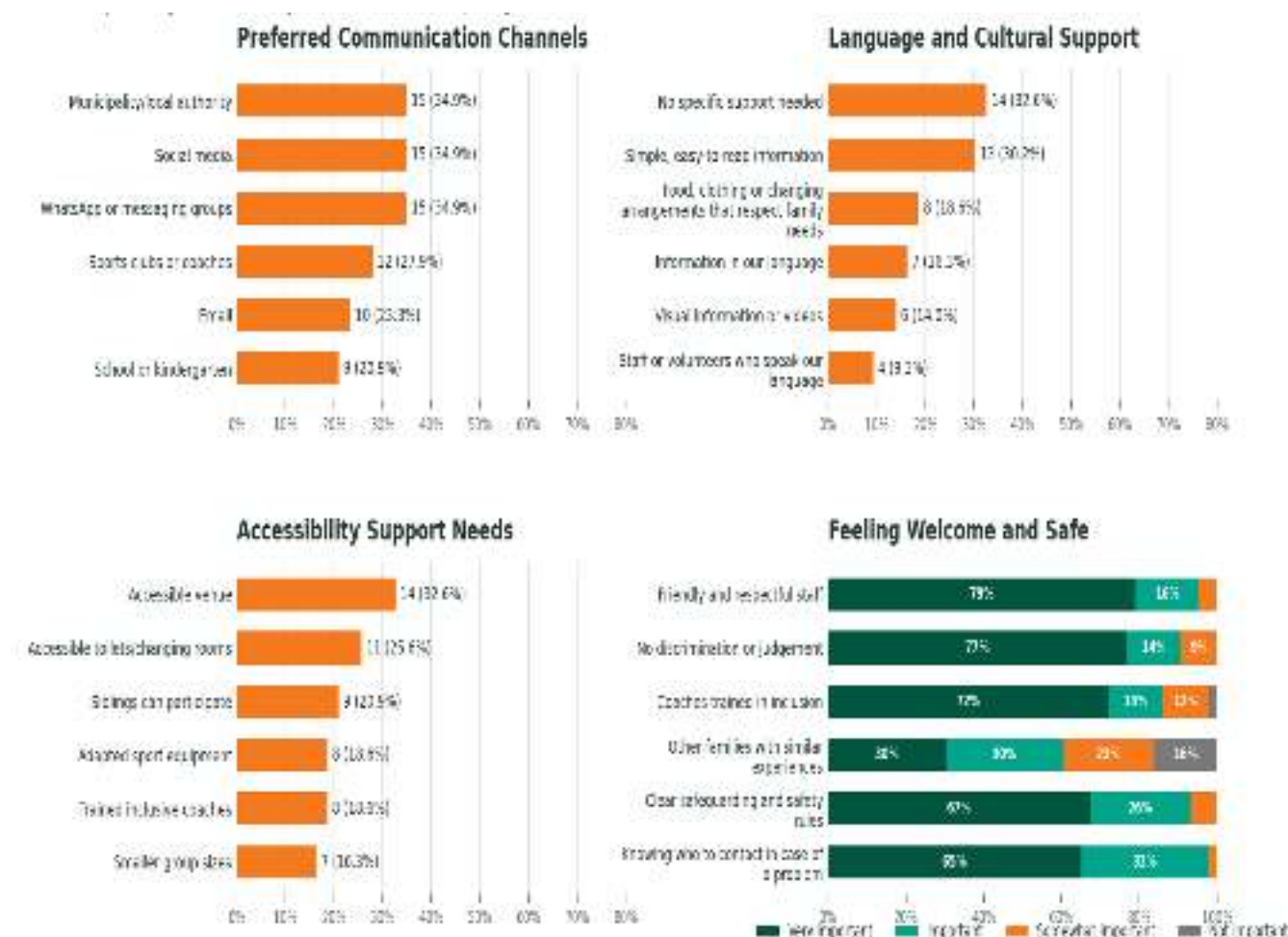


Figure 4.2.4 Italy communication language and accessibility priorities

Source: Italy survey, $n = 43$.

The interviews add a strong infrastructure theme that is only partially visible in the survey. Participants discussed unreliable access to school gyms, broken bathrooms, unusable showers, cold facilities and short-term arrangements that discourage clubs from improving public spaces. One participant observed: “It is not enough to buy [a facility], you have to maintain it”.

The findings show that maintenance is an inclusion issue. A facility may exist geographically but remain unusable if its toilets, showers, heating, accessibility or scheduling arrangements are inadequate. Another participant described public school gyms that could serve densely populated neighbourhoods but were unavailable at weekends and governed by uncertain short-term concessions.

Coaching relationships also shape continuity. Knowing whom to contact was important or very important to 97.7%, friendly staff to 95.3% and safeguarding to

93.0%. One participant summarised what supports continued involvement as “the coach’s enthusiasm and the environment”. These findings indicate that trust is created through everyday delivery, not only formal safeguarding statements.

Family Perspectives from Q15 and Interviews

Among the 30 substantive Italian Q15 responses, affordability was identified in 14, welcome or trust in nine, accessibility in six and information in five. Although many responses were brief, they consistently linked economic access with organisational responsibility. One respondent called for sport to be made accessible by “reducing costs and offering financial help”, while also facilitating foreign families’ registration through clear information and language support (I-Q15-39). Another asked for free activities delivered through public funding in schools or locations close to families’ homes (I-Q15-18).

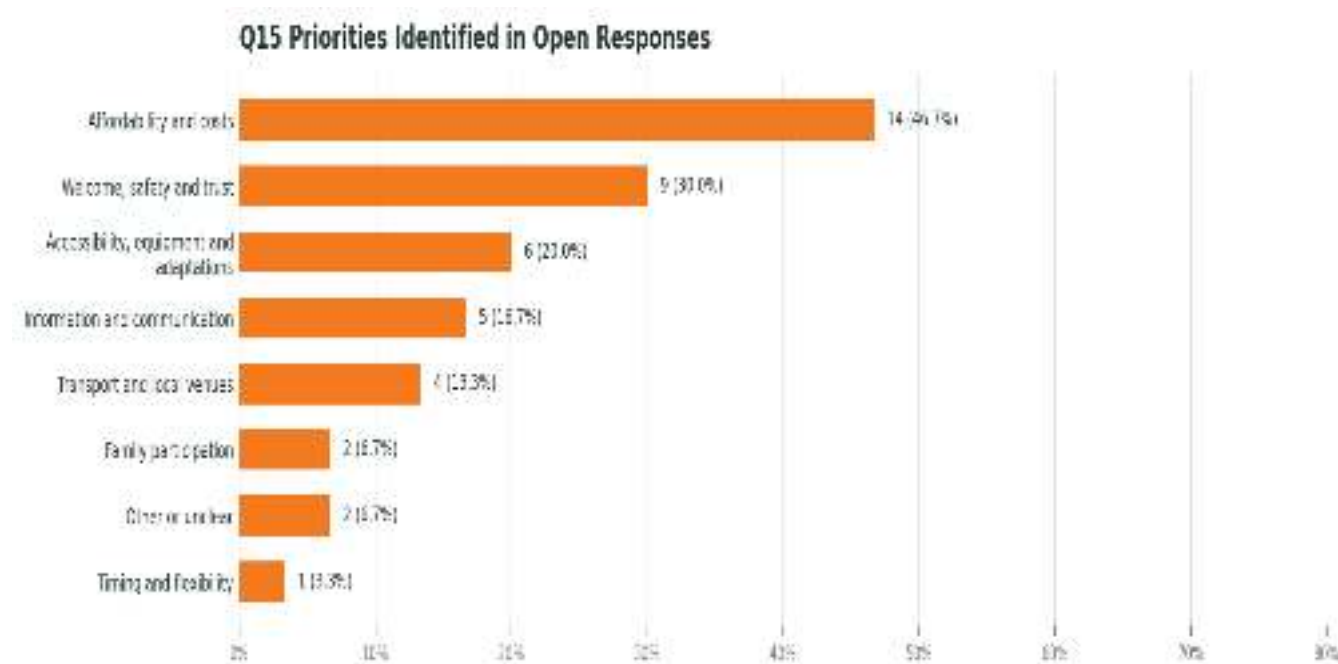


Figure 4.2.5 Italy Q15 themes and anonymised perspectives

Source: 30 substantive Q15 responses. Responses may carry several themes.

Facility quality also appeared directly in the open responses. One participant urged organisations not to abandon sport facilities but to keep them welcoming through “order, cleanliness, necessary materials available, trained and informed staff” (I-Q15-20). Another requested adequate infrastructure and assistance for families with younger children. These responses anticipate one of the most important interview findings: in Italy, infrastructure management is not a separate technical issue but a condition that determines who can participate.

Themes Across Interviews

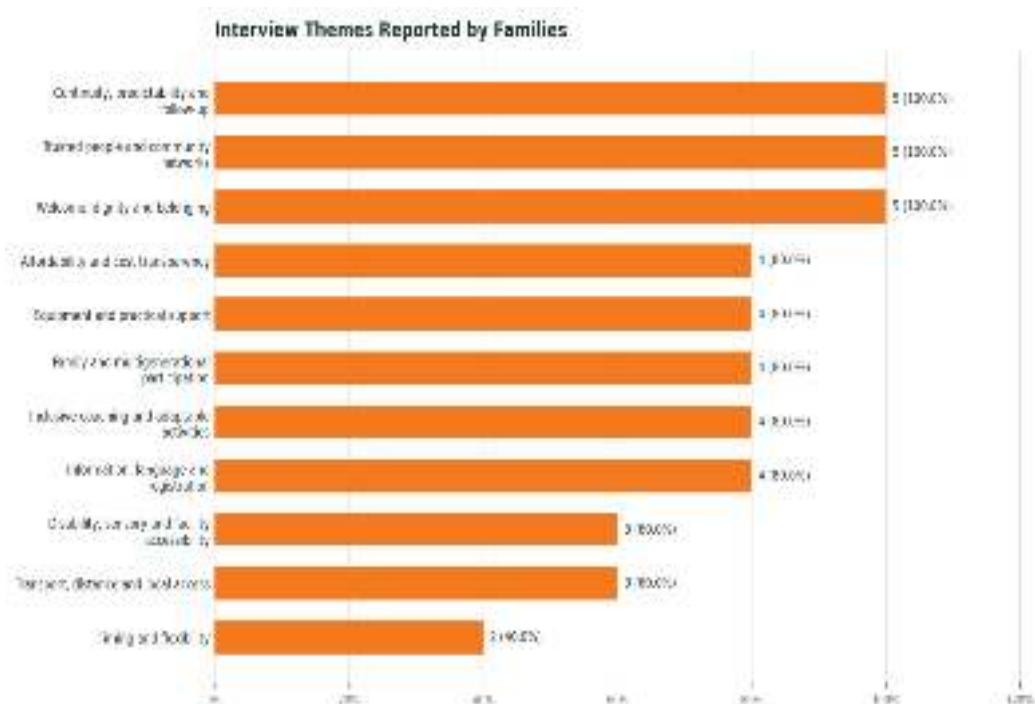


Figure 4.2.6 Italy interview themes

Source: Five interviews. Each interview may carry several themes.

The first interview presented sport as a source of respect, self-awareness, relationships and confidence. However, the participant described substantial costs once a child entered organised or competitive sport. The family had declined an important two-day tournament in France because it would have cost almost €300 and the club had no funds to assist. This example demonstrates how participation may be affordable at the entry level while progression becomes inaccessible. The participant argued that sport federations should support free opportunities for children to try different activities at public events. The family's experience also exposed the long-term costs of facilities. The participant compared a sport facility to a car: building it is not enough because grass, flooring, showers, heating, electricity and repairs require continuing expenditure. Broken toilets and showers affected the experience even when the coaching was positive. The interview therefore adds a temporal dimension to infrastructure: initial capital investment does not guarantee sustained access if maintenance funding and responsibility are unclear.

The second interview came from competitive sport and sharply distinguished children's participation from family participation. The participant stated: **"In the world of competitive sport, there's no 'doing sport together'... parents aren't encouraged to share in the experience. Parents pay."** Although parents had occasionally organised informal recreational competitions themselves, this was not integrated into normal club practice. The participant identified a gap between children belonging to a team and the family being included in the sporting experience. Continued participation depended strongly on "the coach's enthusiasm and the environment", while events had to be actively organised and effectively promoted rather than assumed to happen spontaneously (I-INT2).

The third interview concentrated on urban logistics and public facilities. Different family members used facilities in different parts of the city, and one child's club depended on uncertain access to a school gym. The participant described how families with cars, flexible employment and greater financial resources were more able to compensate for fragmented provision: **"In the end it's the people who are already better off who manage to make it work."**

By contrast, families dependent on public transport or fixed employment were more exposed to inconvenient locations and schedules. The participant also described short and unstable concessions for sport organisations using school facilities. Clubs might be willing to repair showers or improve flooring, but they had little incentive to invest when access could disappear after one or two years. This offers a particularly valuable institutional insight: physical infrastructure may exist but remain underused because responsibility, access and investment rights are fragmented.

The fourth interview described shift work and family scheduling. The participant worked nights, while her husband travelled for work. The family could barely coordinate the children's separate classes, and the grandmother frequently provided transport. The participant said safety was the first priority because one child had needed months of patient support to overcome fear of deep water.

Scheduling was a greater barrier than price: **"If I had to choose between paying more for a class with more convenient hours or paying less with inconvenient ones, I'd always choose the former."** The family wanted weekend provision, make-up sessions, school-based activities immediately after lessons, sibling discounts and possibly transport from school to sport. The participant concluded that families involving shift workers were overlooked because **"everything is designed around people with standard office hours" (I-INT4)**. This lived experience explains why timing cannot be addressed by simply offering an afternoon session.

The fifth interview compared coaches motivated by the values of sport with organisations focused primarily on performance or profit. The participant saw nearby, efficient facilities as a way to reduce costs and argued for stronger collaboration between schools and clubs. School buses could potentially take children directly to sport provision. However, the participant had seen very few genuinely family-oriented events in the sports practised by the children, reinforcing the quantitative finding that opportunities designed for families were insufficient.

Across the Italian interviews, family participation, facilities, coaching and institutional coordination are inseparable. The evidence does not suggest that families reject sport. On the contrary, participants spoke positively about its educational and social value. The problem is that conventional structures frequently treat families as providers of money, transport and administrative support rather than participants with their own needs.

Italy's Conclusion

Italy's comparatively high participation rate should therefore be interpreted carefully. It indicates substantial involvement in sport, but not necessarily equitable

access to family-centred sport. The leading survey barrier, lack of family opportunities, is supported by interview accounts in which parents remain spectators, drivers and payers. The interviews also reveal that continued participation can become more financially demanding as children progress into tournaments, travel and specialist equipment. A programme may be affordable initially while its progression pathway is not.

The Italian findings also identify the importance of the institutional environment surrounding the activity. Families require suitable schedules, local provision, reliable facilities and people who understand household constraints. Public school gyms could provide neighbourhood access, but unstable concessions, restricted hours and weak maintenance arrangements limit their usefulness. Coaches can generate trust, confidence and belonging, but they cannot compensate indefinitely for inaccessible facilities or fragmented organisation. The central opportunity is therefore to connect family-centred programming with maintained local infrastructure, stable school-club cooperation, transparent full costs and human guidance for families navigating the system.

4.3 Latvia

The Latvia sample contains 41 survey responses and five interviews. Its most distinctive quantitative result is the prominence of timing, while the qualitative evidence stresses the practical load carried by larger families and the importance of regular, predictable opportunities.

Indicator	Result	Interpretation
Participation	22 of 41 (53.7%)	Close to the five-country average
Leading constraint	Unsuitable times - 23 of 41 (56.1%)	Scheduling is the first design issue
Preferred timing	Flexible - 48.8%; School holidays - 43.9%	Families need several workable windows
Background indicators	Not populated	No disability financial or migrant cards should be inferred

Constraints and Participation Profile

Latvia's participation rate of 53.7% is close to the five-country average, but timing is unusually prominent. Unsuitable times were selected by 56.1%, followed by lack of information at 39.0% and cost at 36.6%. Timing should not be interpreted as a minor scheduling preference: for families, it determines whether work, school, childcare, travel and the needs of several children can be coordinated.

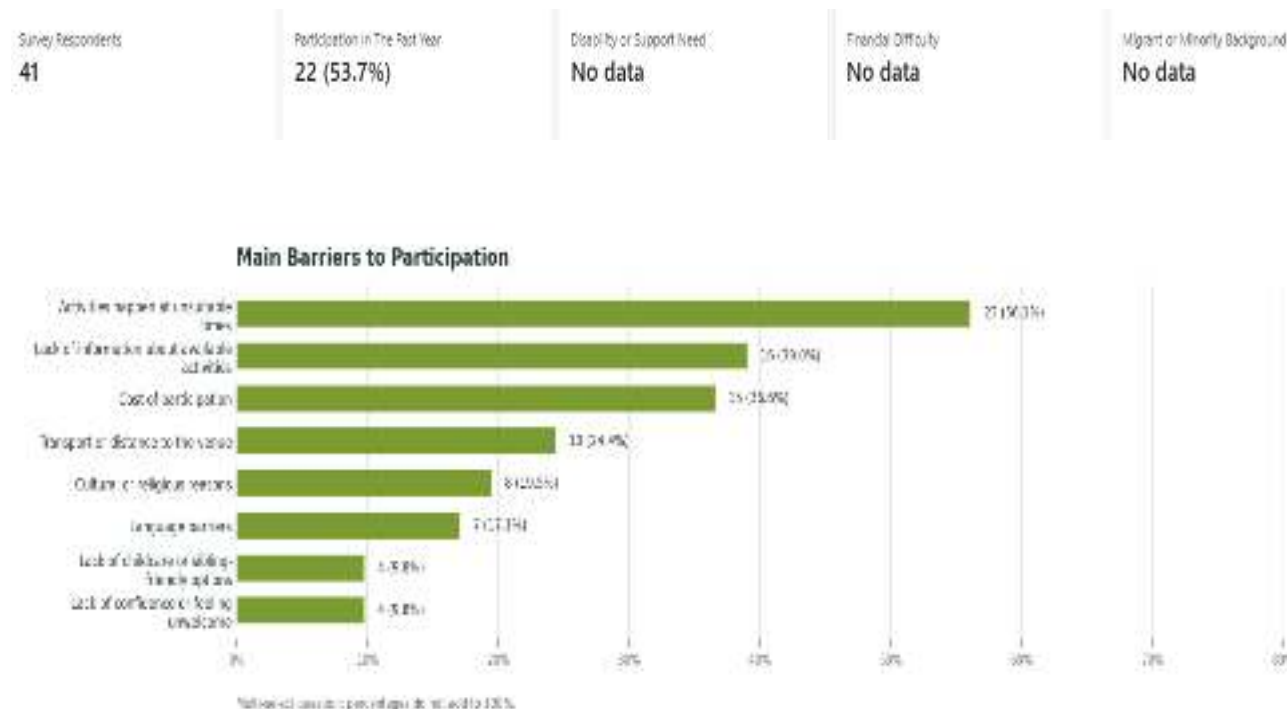


Figure 4.3.1 Latvia participation profile and main barriers

Source: Latvia survey, $n = 41$. Barrier percentages are multi-select.

Affordability and Cost Transparency

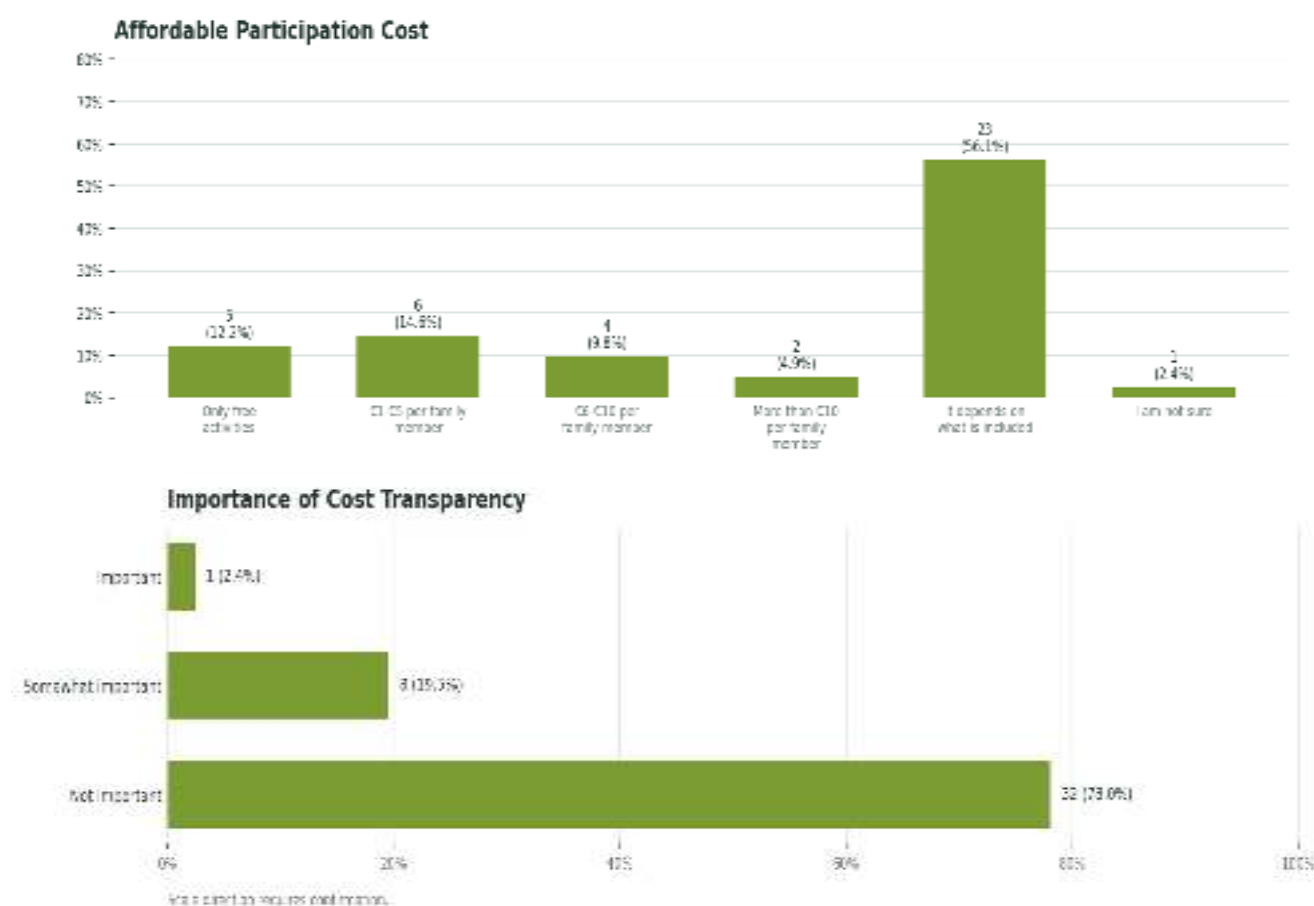


Figure 4.3.2 Latvia affordability and cost transparency

Source: Latvia survey, $n = 41$. Q4 is not interpreted because its coding direction requires confirmation.

Latvia differs very sharply from the other four country samples in its assessment of cost transparency. Of the 41 respondents, 32, or 78.0%, said that advance explanation of the full cost was not important. A further eight respondents, or 19.5%, considered it somewhat important, while only one respondent, or 2.4%, considered it important. No respondent selected very important. This is not evidence that cost itself is irrelevant. Cost was identified as a participation barrier by 15 respondents, or 36.6%, while 23 respondents, or 56.1%, said that an affordable amount depended on what was included. The results therefore reveal a distinction between concern about affordability and concern about formal advance cost transparency.

Latvian families appear to be sensitive to the overall value and practical content of an activity, but most did not identify a detailed explanation of every possible cost before registration as an important decision criterion. Several interpretations are possible, and the data do not allow one explanation to be selected conclusively. Respondents may focus primarily on whether the final price is manageable, rather than whether every cost component is presented separately. They may also expect to obtain practical information through familiar organisers, schools or community networks rather than through a formal cost breakdown. Alternatively, cost transparency may be regarded as a basic expectation that does not require particular emphasis. These possibilities should be treated as interpretations rather than established explanations.

The contrast with the other countries is nevertheless substantial. In Estonia, Italy, Greece and Spain combined, 151 of 167 respondents, or 90.4%, rated cost transparency as important or very important. In Latvia, only one of 41 respondents did so. A single five-country percentage would conceal this marked divergence and would not represent either the Latvian pattern or that of the other four countries accurately. The Latvia result suggests that interventions should distinguish between reducing costs, demonstrating value and communicating a detailed cost breakdown. In Latvia, the stronger immediate concerns appear to be whether the overall offer is affordable, what is included, whether it takes place at a workable time and whether the family can reach it. Cost communication remains necessary as a matter of responsible delivery, but it may not be the most persuasive participation message for this sample.

Offer Design and Continuity

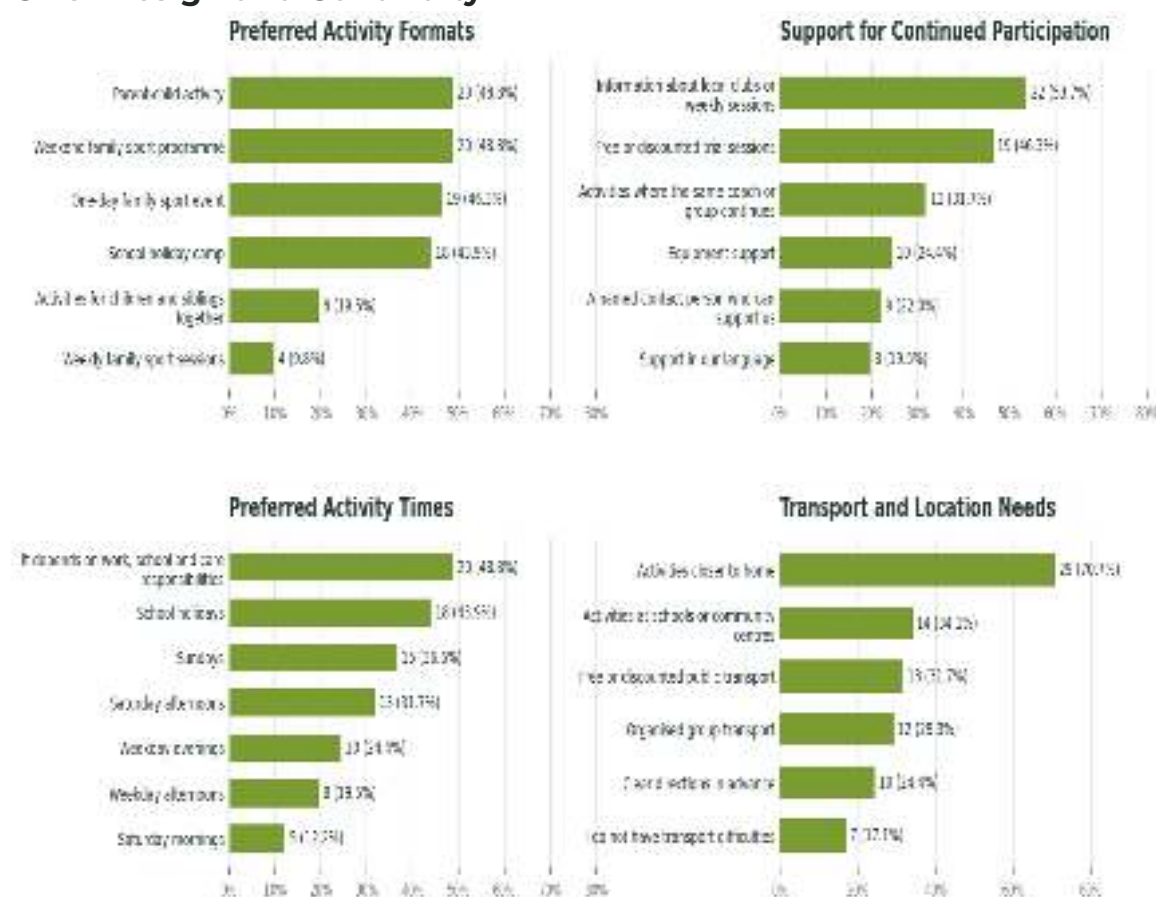


Figure 4.3.3 Latvia preferred formats and continuation support

Source: Latvia survey, $n = 41$. Both questions allowed up to three selections.

Weekend programmes and parent-child activities were joint leading formats at 48.8%, followed by one-day events and school-holiday camps. Weekly sessions were selected by only 9.8%. This does not indicate a lack of interest in continuity. Information about local clubs or weekly sessions was the leading continuation support, at 53.7%, and free or discounted trials reached 46.3%. Families appear to want continuity that is flexible and compatible with household life rather than an inflexible weekly commitment.

This distinction is visible in Q15: “It is often hard to commit to weekly trainings. Would be nice to have options that take place, for example, one or two times a month” (L-Q15-23). Regularity can therefore mean a predictable monthly or seasonal rhythm rather than weekly attendance.

The interviews make large-family logistics particularly visible. One participant explained that small individual costs become substantial when multiplied across family members, while another described parents having to choose which child can participate when an activity allows only one child at a time. Trial periods were valued because they reduce the risk of paying membership and equipment costs before knowing whether the routine will work.

Almost half of respondents required flexibility around work, school and care; 43.9% selected school holidays and 36.6% Sundays. Activities closer to home were selected

by 70.7%, while public transport and group transport were also relevant. Taken together, the chart describes a need for several predictable participation windows and reduced travel complexity.

Information, Inclusion, and Welcome



Figure 4.3.4 Latvia communication language and accessibility priorities

Source: Latvia survey, $n = 41$.

Schools and kindergartens were the strongest communication channel at 58.5%, followed by social media at 53.7% and email at 41.5%. Own-language information was selected by 53.7%, simple information by 43.9% and clear advance accessibility information by the same proportion.

The interview findings show that information must be operational rather than promotional. Families want to know the time, location, cost, registration process, food arrangements, parking, toilets, seating and what children of different ages can do. As one Q15 respondent wrote: “All of the information about the event [should be] communicated: will there be an option to sit down, tables and food options, toilets, etc.”.

Latvia also presents a distinctive pattern in relation to the conditions associated with feeling welcome and safe. Most respondents did not rate formal welcome and safety conditions as important to their participation decision. This differs substantially from Estonia, Italy, Greece and Spain, where friendly staff, freedom from discrimination, safeguarding and knowing whom to contact received consistently high ratings.

Friendly and respectful staff were rated not important by 35 Latvian respondents, or 85.4%, and somewhat important by six, or 14.6%. No respondent rated this condition as important or very important. Similarly, 32 respondents, or 78.0%, said that freedom from discrimination or judgement was not important; eight, or 19.5%, considered it somewhat important; and one, or 2.4%, considered it important.

Clear safeguarding and safety rules were rated not important by 22 respondents, or 53.7%, and somewhat important by 15, or 36.6%. Four respondents, or 9.8%, rated them as important. Knowing whom to contact in case of a problem was rated not important by 20 respondents, or 48.8%, and somewhat important by 18, or 43.9%. Only three respondents, or 7.3%, considered this important.

Trained inclusive coaches received somewhat greater recognition. Eight respondents, or 19.5%, rated this as important or very important; 13, or 31.7%, considered it somewhat important; and 20, or 48.8%, considered it not important. However, even this result remains considerably lower than in the other four samples.

The highest-rated Q12 condition in Latvia was the presence of other families with similar experiences. Eighteen respondents, or 43.9%, rated this as important or very important. Nine respondents selected very important, nine important, nine somewhat important and 14 not important. Although this condition still did not receive majority support, its relative position is revealing. Latvian respondents appear to attach more importance to familiarity and social connection with other families than to formal organisational assurances about staff, safeguarding or contact procedures.

This pattern should not be interpreted as showing that Latvian families favour unsafe, disrespectful or discriminatory environments. A more cautious interpretation is that these conditions did not strongly influence respondents' stated decision about whether to join an activity. Families may regard respectful behaviour and safety as normal baseline expectations rather than features that need to be actively considered. The closed responses may also indicate that practical considerations such as timing, proximity, transport and affordability are more immediate in the participation decision.

The qualitative findings add an important qualification. Welcome, dignity or belonging appeared in all five Latvian interviews, as did trusted people and community networks. Welcome, safety or trust also appeared in 11 of the 41 Q15 responses. One Q15 respondent asked for a "non-judgmental atmosphere where beginners feel just as valued as experienced participants" and argued that activities should "foster a sense of community, helping families build friendships and feel they belong" (L-Q15-9). Another respondent emphasised "friendly staff and support from coaches" alongside accessibility and suitability for the whole family (L-Q15-22).

Interview participants similarly described familiar faces, friendly organisers and a sense of community as reasons why family activity was enjoyable. One family explained that participants and organisers could begin to feel "like friends or members of one larger group" and that seeing familiar people made participation

easier. Another stated that language differences could initially be challenging but that an open and welcoming attitude made communication possible.

The quantitative and qualitative findings therefore point in different directions, and this divergence should be retained rather than artificially resolved. The closed Q12 scale suggests that formal welcome and safety criteria were not decisive for most survey respondents. The interviews and Q15 responses show that relational experiences, community, friendliness and belonging still matter to at least some families. One possible interpretation is that Latvian participants respond more strongly to welcome when it is expressed through familiar people and shared experience than when it is presented as an abstract organisational condition.

For intervention planning, the findings suggest that Latvian family sport offers should lead with the practical conditions families rated most strongly: workable schedules, local delivery, affordable participation, clear activity information and family-appropriate design. Respectful staff, safeguarding and clear contact arrangements must still be maintained as essential standards, even if they are not strong promotional motivators. Community-based delivery and the involvement of familiar families may provide a particularly relevant route for building comfort and continued participation.

Family Perspectives from Q15 and Interviews

Latvia's Q15 responses were distributed across several themes. Affordability, welcome and accessibility each appeared in 11 of 41 responses; information and timing in ten each; family participation in nine; and transport in three. This distribution confirms that Latvia's timing problem is part of a broader household-management challenge.

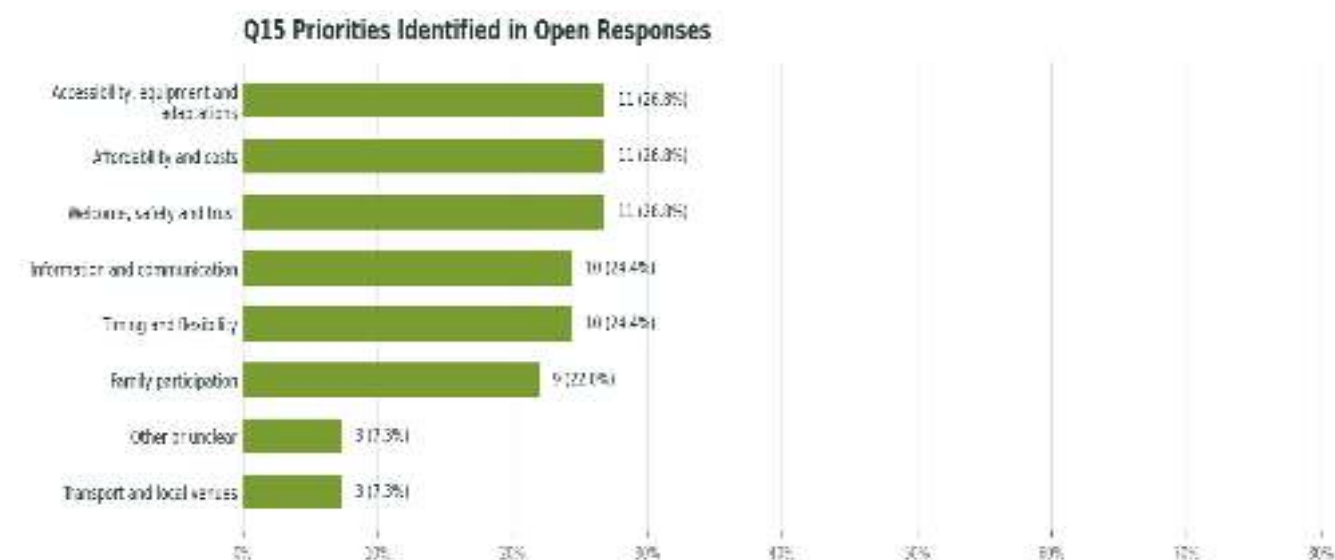


Figure 4.3.5 Latvia Q15 themes and anonymised perspectives

Source: 41 substantive Q15 responses. Responses may carry several themes.

One particularly detailed response asked for activities in which parents and children participate together, a non-judgemental atmosphere, affordable fees, simple registration and convenient schedules. It argued that family sport should prioritise

“fun, connection and wellbeing over competition and results” and provide flexibility so that missing a session does not leave a family feeling permanently behind. The respondent concluded: **“When families leave feeling more connected than when they arrived, they’re much more likely to return” (L-Q15-9).**

Other responses focused on the practical environment. Families wanted to know whether seating, food and toilets were available. Respondents also requested baby-changing areas, wider paths for pushchairs, lower noise levels and places for families to sit and eat. These comments broaden accessibility beyond disability categories and show how babies and young children shape whether a whole family can attend.

Themes Across Interviews

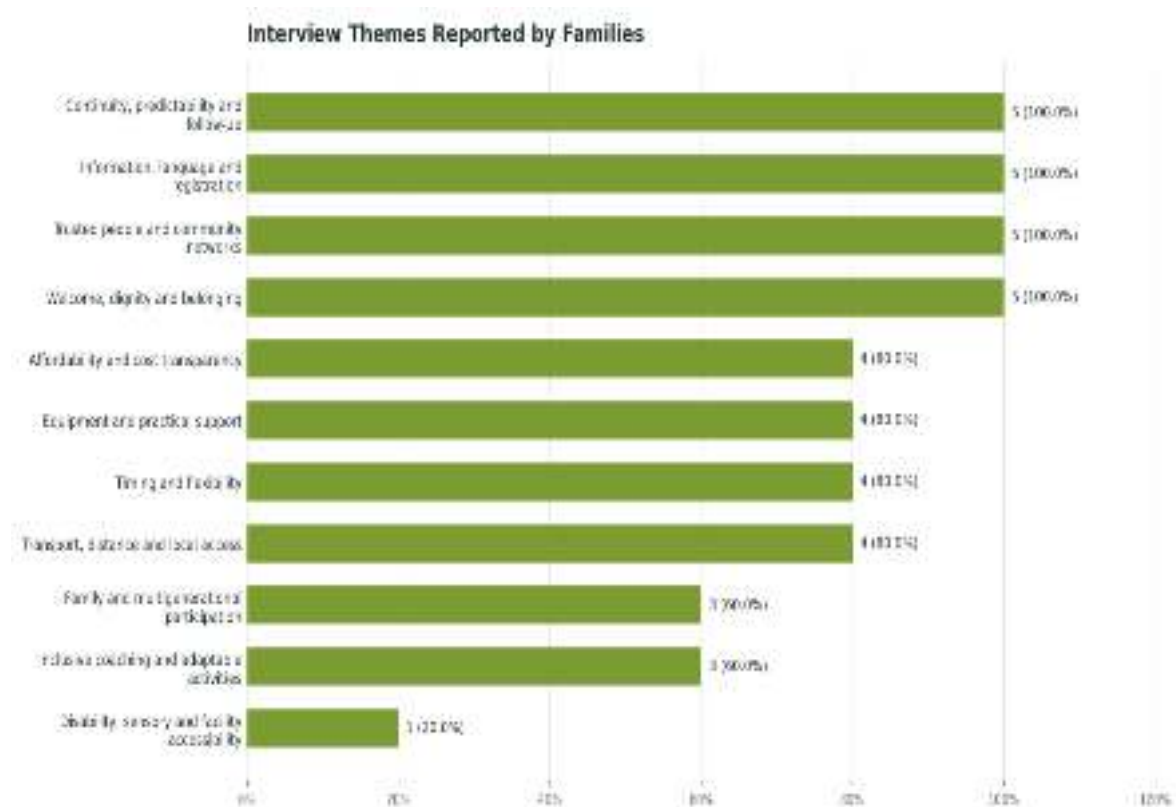


Figure 4.3.6 Latvia interview themes

Source: Five interviews. Each interview may carry several themes.

The first interview described organised family activity as valuable because it brought the household together and supported communication and cooperation. Participation became easier when activities were affordable, close to home and outside working hours. Information also needed to be easy to find. The participant called for publicly funded or subsidised programmes with enough places available, but also mentioned details such as free parking, drinking water, food and small participation incentives. These apparently minor elements can determine whether an event feels organised and welcoming or transfers additional costs and effort to the family.

The second interview emphasised the social environment. Familiar faces and friendly organisers could make participants feel part of “one larger group”. Trying to communicate with people from other backgrounds was initially challenging but could strengthen confidence. This participant had not encountered a major barrier to attending again; the main problem was that suitable family opportunities were not organised often enough. This is useful counter-evidence: not every family requires intensive individual support, but even motivated families cannot participate regularly when provision is sporadic.

The third interview focused on larger-family costs and childcare. Even a relatively small per-person fee became substantial when multiplied across several family members. When an activity was unsuitable for very young children, the family needed parallel activities or supervision so that other members could participate.

The participant also observed that general promotion might not reach disadvantaged families and called for direct outreach rather than assuming that families would independently find the information. This interview demonstrates how an apparently inclusive family event can still require a parent to remain outside the activity caring for a younger child. Inclusion therefore depends on whether the programme accommodates different ages simultaneously, not simply whether several family members are permitted to register.

The fourth interview described a family already comfortable with sport. Its primary need was accurate information about what, where and when. Free or inexpensive activity, proximity, evenings and weekends supported attendance. For continuity, distance and regularity were critical. The participant noted that trying an activity once could make it attractive and understandable, but suitable opportunities then had to be available regularly so that interest could become a habit.

The fifth interview offered the most detailed account of large-family logistics. The participant explained that activities allowing only one child or family member to participate forced parents to decide who received the opportunity. A more inclusive design would allow children of different ages to complete suitable challenges while contributing to a shared family result. Transport involved not only distance but fuel, parking and the work of preparing everyone to leave home. Parents had to ensure that children had eaten, had suitable clothing, arrived on time and remained comfortable throughout a long event. Younger children might require rest periods and quiet activities such as drawing, crafts or puzzles. These provisions would support participation by the whole family rather than requiring early departure. The participant also raised a distinctive concern about public competition results. Displaying scores continuously could increase comparison and pressure. Delaying or limiting public results could preserve enjoyment and reduce anxiety. This complements Q15's preference for family connection over performance.

For continuation, the family recommended one or two free trial months, allowing children to discover whether they enjoyed the activity before the household paid for membership and equipment. The participant explained that regular participation might involve club fees, competitions, venue charges and replacement equipment as children grew. These costs could become difficult even for households not formally classified as low-income.

The participant also asked organisations to recognise varied family structures, including single-parent families, foster families, children raised by grandparents and families in which parents work elsewhere. Provision should not assume a fixed two-adult, two-child household. The interview concluded that the challenge was to make family opportunities "regular, geographically accessible, financially realistic and flexible enough to include the wide variety of families that exist in society" (L-INT5).

The contrast between the closed Q12 responses and the qualitative evidence is analytically valuable. It shows why the interviews cannot be treated merely as illustrations of the survey. If only the closed scale were examined, the conclusion would be that welcome, respectful staff and safety arrangements had little relevance

in Latvia. The interviews reveal a more nuanced picture in which families value community, familiar people, supportive organisers and a sense of belonging, but may not conceptualise these experiences through formal terms such as safeguarding, anti-discrimination or a designated contact person.

This distinction may also help explain why “other families with similar experiences” was the highest-rated Q12 condition. Latvian families may derive confidence less from formal assurances and more from seeing people like themselves participate comfortably. In the interviews, familiar faces reduced the sense of entering an unknown environment, while positive shared experiences encouraged families to return. This suggests that welcome may be experienced relationally and collectively, even when respondents do not rate individual organisational criteria as important.

At the same time, the report should not assume that every respondent interpreted the scale identically or that the qualitative participants speak for the entire survey sample. The interview group contained only five families and was selected separately. The appropriate conclusion is therefore that Latvia contains a genuine difference between the dominant closed-response pattern and the more relational understanding of welcome found in the qualitative material.

Latvia's Conclusion

Latvia's results identify practical household organisation as the most immediate influence on participation. Unsuitable timing was the leading barrier, while families also prioritised proximity, transport, affordability, advance information and formats that could accommodate parents and children together. The interviews demonstrate that these factors interact: a household must coordinate employment, school, several children, meals, equipment, travel and the needs of younger family members before participation can begin. The Latvian evidence consequently favours predictable but flexible provision, particularly during weekends and school holidays, delivered close to home and communicated sufficiently early.

Latvia is also the clearest country example of why apparently related concepts should not be treated as interchangeable. Respondents were concerned about cost and frequently said affordability depended on what was included, yet 78.0 % did not regard advance full-cost transparency as important. Most respondents also did not rate formal welcome and safety conditions as important, despite Q15 and interview accounts that valued community, familiar people, friendly organisers and belonging. The results suggest that respondents distinguish between practical factors that determine whether attendance is possible and relational qualities that shape the experience once participation occurs.

The country findings should therefore not be interpreted as meaning that cost information, safety or respectful treatment can be neglected. These remain basic responsibilities of any inclusive programme. Rather, the distinctive Latvia pattern indicates that they may not be the strongest stated participation motivators. Families appear more immediately responsive to usable schedules, affordable overall offers, local opportunities, clear operational information and provision that

accommodates different family members. Welcome may be communicated most effectively through familiar community settings, supportive organisers and visible participation by other families, rather than through formal assurances alone.

4.4 Greece

The Greece sample contains 41 survey responses and five interviews.

Indicator	Result	Interpretation
Participation	19 of 41 (46.3%)	The only sample where No exceeded Yes
Financial difficulty	22 of 41 (53.7%)	Cost and transport intensify within this subgroup
Migrant or minority background	16 of 41 (39.0%)	Language and clear information are material
Disability or support need	12 of 41 (29.3%)	Venue and coaching access require attention

Constraints and Participation Profile

Greece recorded the lowest participation rate, at 46.3%, and was the only sample in which “No” exceeded “Yes”. Lack of information was the leading barrier at 51.2%, followed by unsuitable timing at 39.0%, cost at 34.1% and transport or distance at 31.7%. The results indicate that some families struggle to identify and reach a suitable activity before questions of motivation or programme quality can be tested.



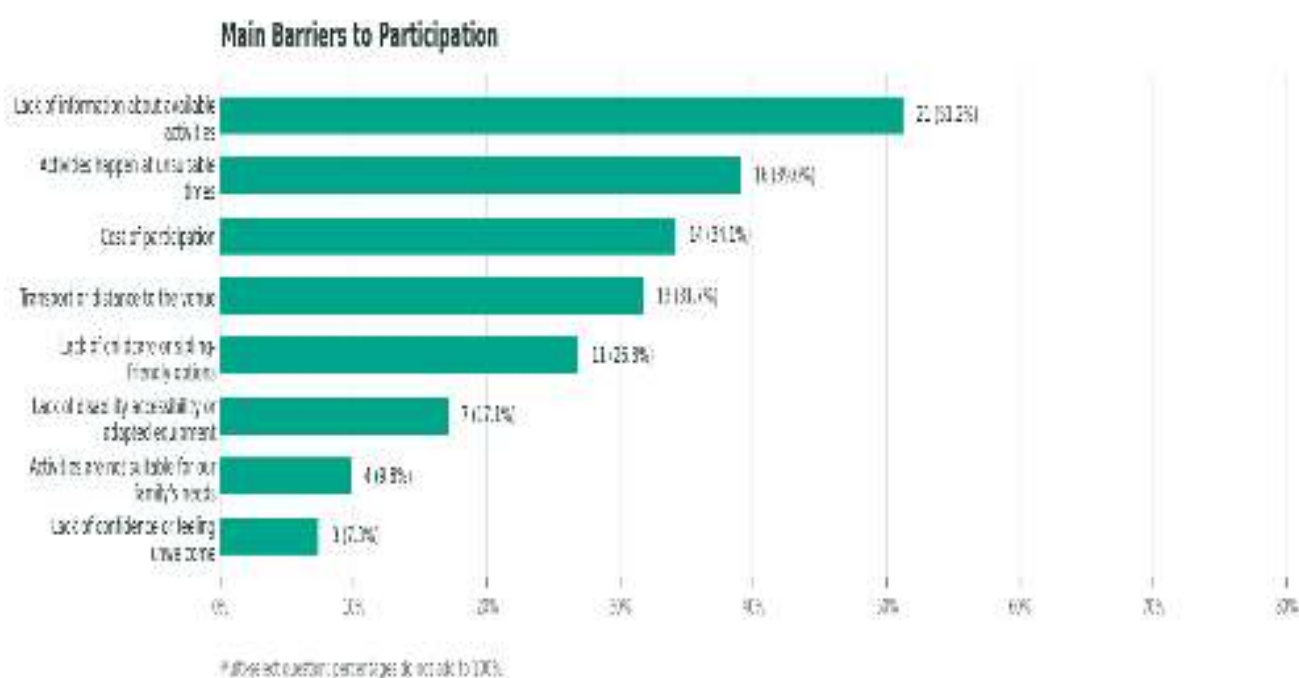


Figure 4.4.1 Greece participation profile and main barriers

Source: Greece survey, $n = 41$. Barrier percentages are multi-select.

Affordability and Cost Transparency

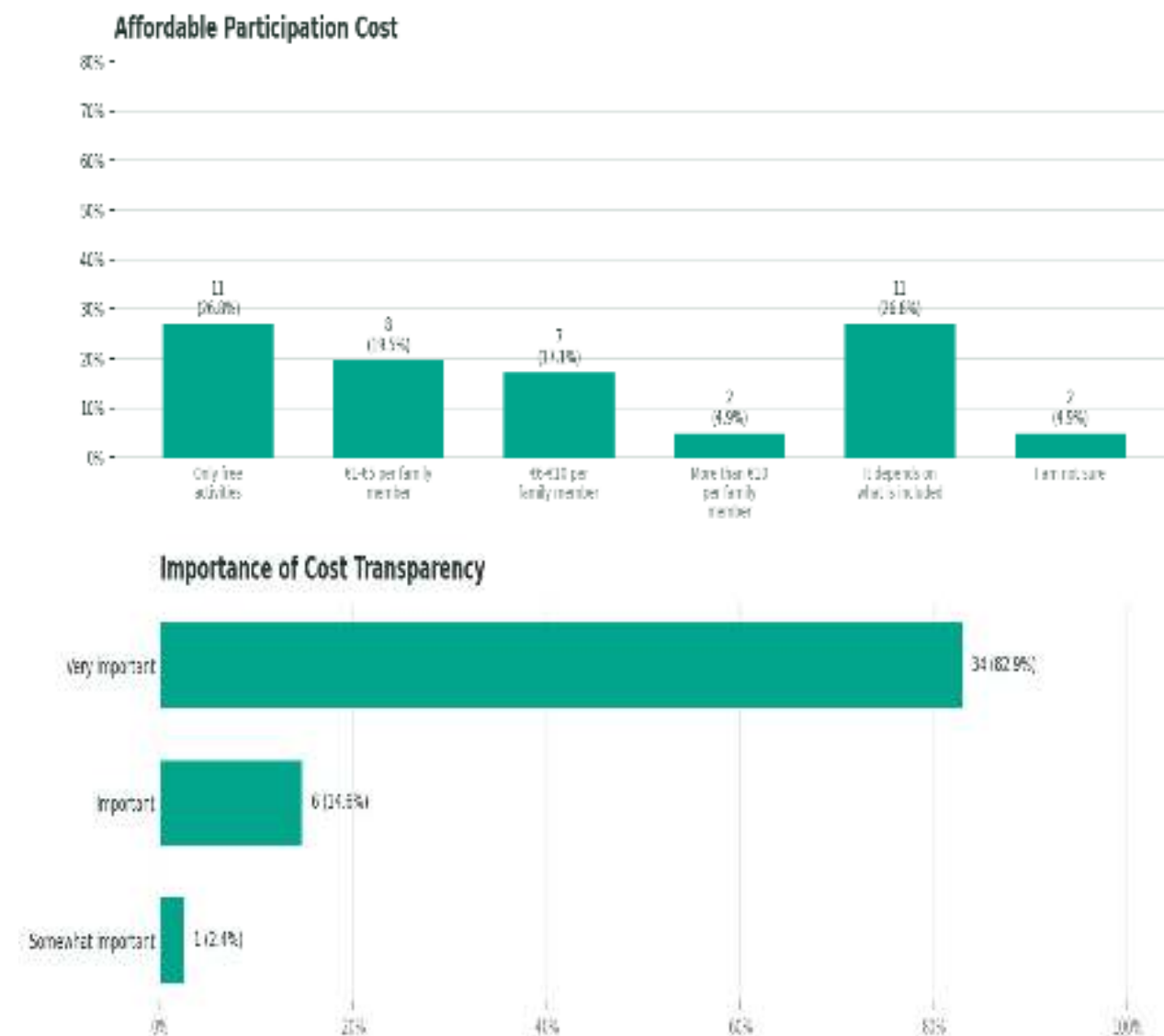


Figure 4.4.2 Greece affordability and cost transparency

Source: Greece survey, $n = 41$.

Within the financial-difficulty subgroup, cost increased to 54.5% and transport to 50.0%. Free participation and “it depends on what is included” were the joint leading affordability answers. Almost all respondents, 97.6%, considered full cost information important or very important. Financial and spatial access are therefore closely connected.

Offer Design and Continuity

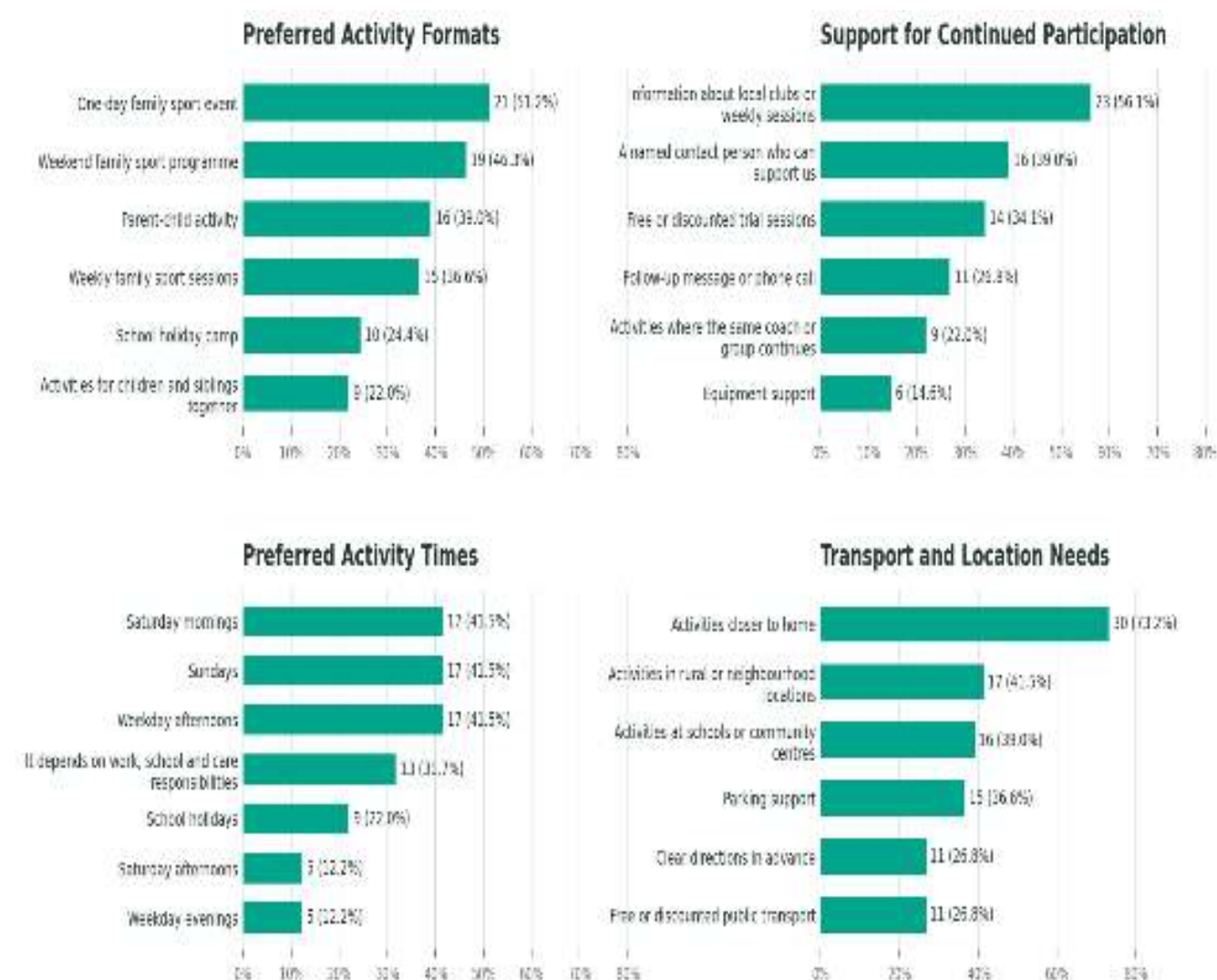


Figure 4.4.3 Greece preferred formats and continuation support

Source: Greece survey, $n = 41$. Both questions allowed up to three selections.

One-day events led format preferences at 51.2%, followed by weekend programmes at 46.3% and parent-child activities at 39.0%. Information about local clubs or weekly sessions was the strongest continuation support. The combination suggests that visible introductory events may be appropriate, but only when they connect participants to something local and recurring.

Activities closer to home were selected by 73.2%, neighbourhood or rural locations by 41.5%, schools or community centres by 39.0% and parking support by 36.6%. These preferences describe more than convenience. They reflect the practical difficulty of crossing urban areas, accommodating disability needs and fitting activity around long working hours.

All five interview participants discussed transport, timing, continuity and family participation. One participant described knowing families who travel 45 minutes for a single activity. Another explained that Sunday was the only time the whole family could participate, but also the family's only opportunity to rest.

Information Inclusion and Welcome

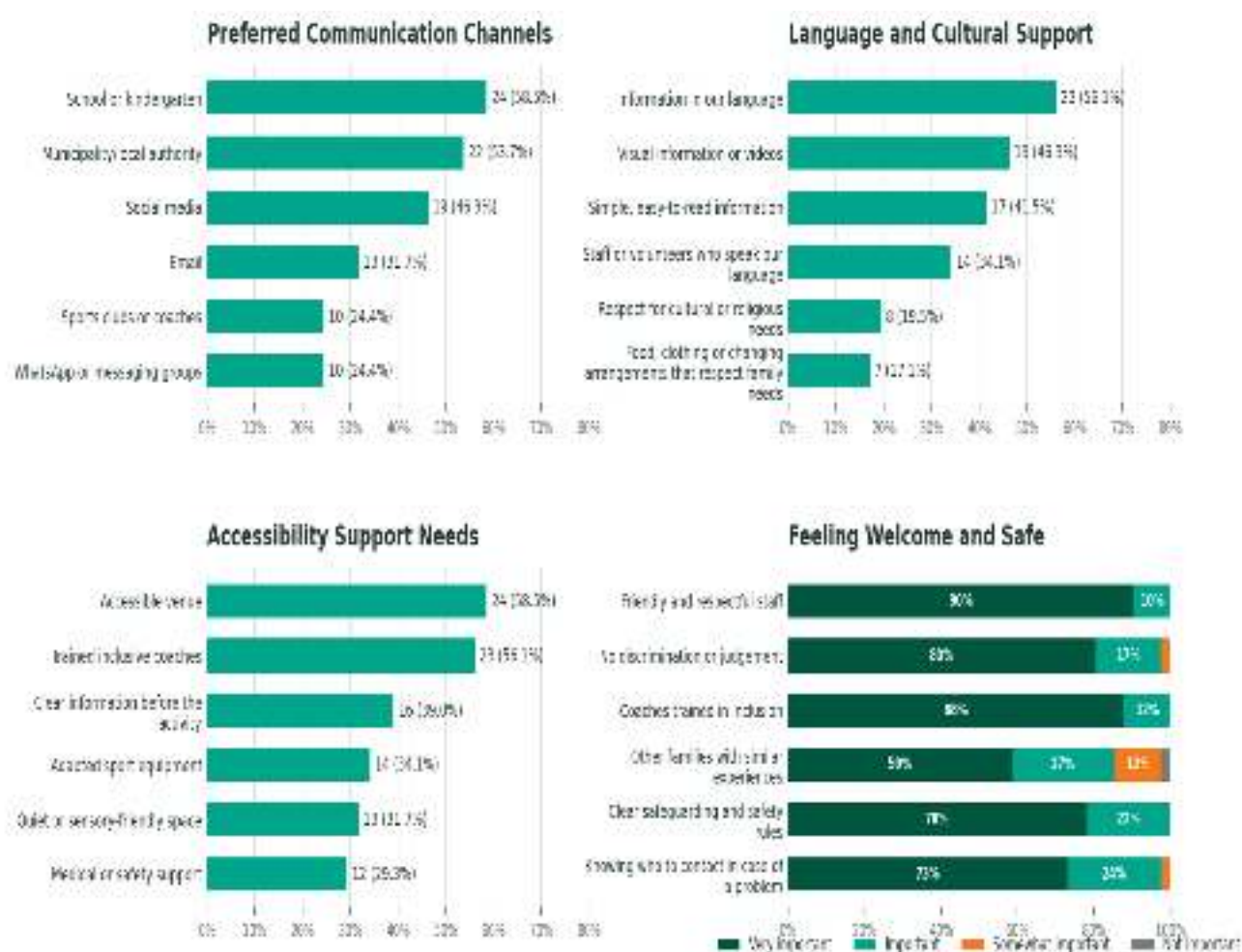


Figure 4.4.4 Greece communication language and accessibility priorities

Source: Greece survey, $n = 41$.

Schools and kindergartens were selected as information channels by 58.5%, municipalities by 53.7% and social media by 46.3%. Information in the family's language, visual information and simple information were all prominent. This suggests that communication should be both institutionally trusted and practically understandable.

Greece recorded the strongest accessibility needs in the survey. Accessible venues were selected by 58.5% and trained inclusive coaches by 56.1%. Friendly staff, trained coaches and safeguarding were important or very important to every respondent. Having other families with similar experiences also received a higher rating than in the other comparable countries, suggesting that peer familiarity may help families enter settings where they otherwise anticipate judgement.

The interviews clarify the distinction between formal and substantive inclusion. One participant reported that families "are not enabled in any way; they are just allowed to join". Difficulties included collecting race materials days in advance, inaccessible parking, sensory overload at event starts and the absence of local activities tailored to neurodiverse children. Being permitted to attend does not amount to inclusion when the surrounding procedure remains unusable.

Family Perspectives from Q15 and Interviews

Among the 33 substantive Greek Q15 responses, welcome and trust appeared in 15, accessibility in 13, information in 12, affordability in nine and family participation in six. The prominence of welcome and accessibility is consistent with the survey's high ratings for trained coaches, suitable venues, safeguarding and respectful treatment.

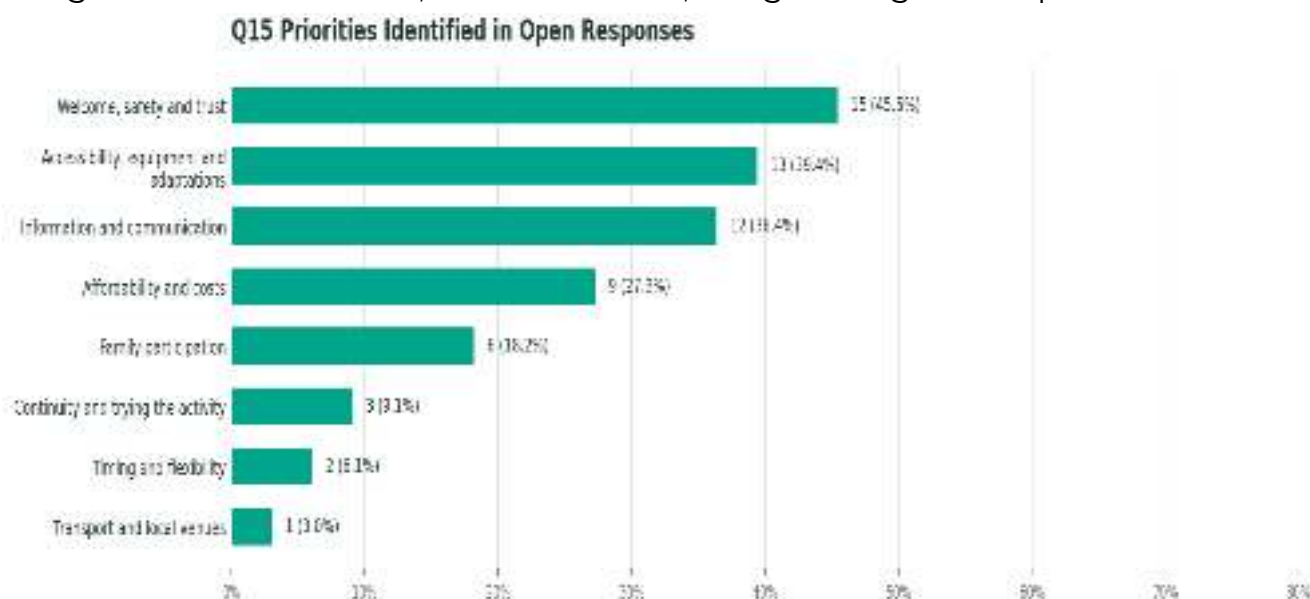


Figure 4.4.5 Greece Q15 themes and anonymised perspectives

Source: 33 substantive Q15 responses. Responses may carry several themes.

Several respondents called for families to be involved in designing activities. One wrote that families should have the opportunity to **“co-create and actively participate in the design and implementation of the activities”** so they could express their actual needs and feel like members of the community (G-Q15-21). Another asked for activities to be **“well-organised, accessible, affordable, and offered regularly”**, together with widespread promotion (G-Q15-38). These responses demonstrate that families want both voice and continuity, not simply invitations to pre-designed activities.

Themes Across Interviews

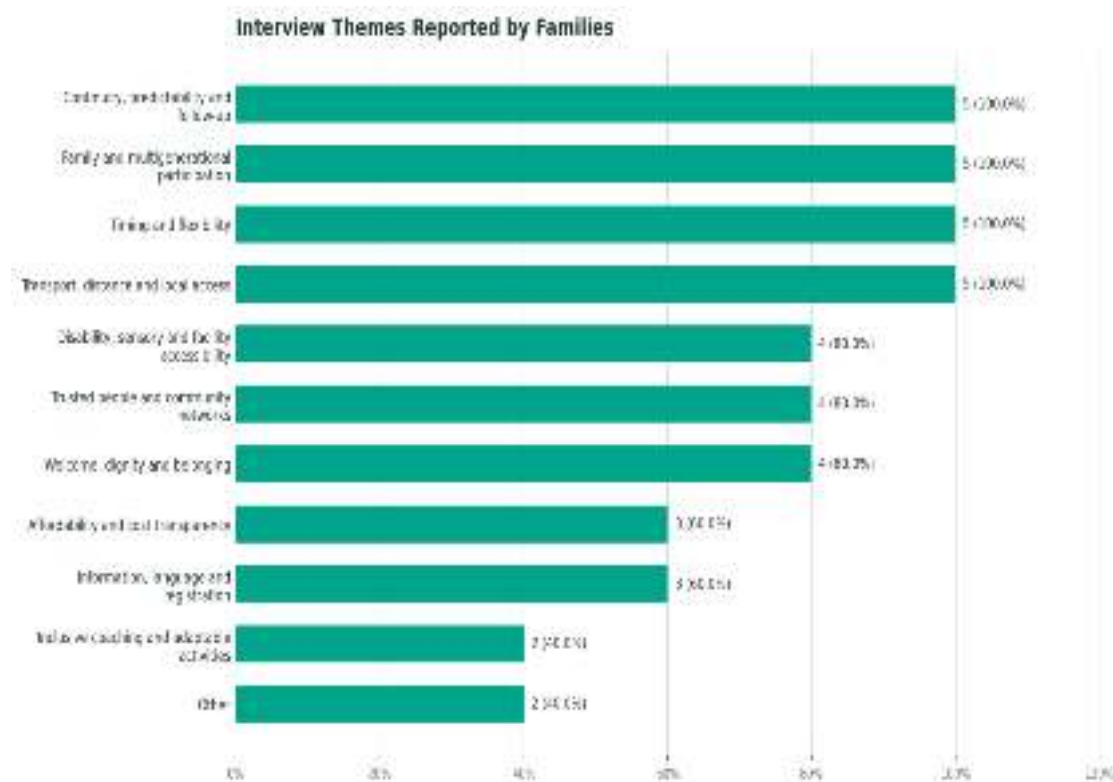


Figure 4.4.6 Greece interview themes

Source: Five interviews. Each interview may carry several themes.

The first interview concerned a family affected by neurodiversity and disability. The participant described a system in which few municipalities offered appropriate activities and families encountered barriers in apparently simple procedures. Registration materials for races sometimes had to be collected two days in advance, requiring additional journeys through Athens's traffic. Parking, assistance with children and crowded event starts also caused difficulty.

The participant summarised the experience powerfully: **“They are not enabled in any way; they are just allowed to join.”** This distinction is central to the Greek evidence. Formal permission to attend does not amount to effective inclusion if families must manage inaccessible registration, transport, sensory conditions and support arrangements themselves. Loud music and horns at race start could cause sensory overload. One child known to the participant left an event and never returned. Later start times, registration on the day, local municipal provision, accessible parking and better information would have reduced the burden. The participant also wanted neurodiverse and neurotypical children to share spaces, with adaptations that allowed both to participate and learn from one another.

The second interview involved a parent of a child with ADHD and autism. Fear of judgement had led the family to prefer disability-specific clubs because they felt safer. The parent found information about appropriate opportunities largely by chance despite working within disability communities. Fees were also difficult, and some families travelled approximately 45 minutes for one activity.

The participant wanted close, weekend-based activities that parent and child could enjoy together. Regular municipal information, recurring events and staff with both sport and special-education expertise could help families build familiarity. Inclusive events should not isolate disability groups but create settings in which all families could participate safely. The participant described an inclusive Sunday football activity for children and parents as an example of what this could look like.

The interview also exposed a significant information failure. The participant felt that families with disabilities received little guidance from schools or public institutions and said that families were **“fighting on their own, without receiving information from anywhere” (G-INT2)**. This statement adds considerable depth to the survey’s information barrier: the problem is not merely insufficient publicity but the absence of a clear institutional route into appropriate provision.

The third interview concerned a migrant family. The participant relied on a long-standing group of other mothers who met in the park and helped with Greek. These trusted relationships reduced judgement and created an informal participation network. The husband worked two jobs, especially during summer, making shared family time limited. The participant preferred activities within walking distance and later in the day. Information about organised opportunities was not reaching the family, even though it was willing to participate.

The fourth interview, also outside the capital, described a smaller city in which distance was less problematic but working hours remained restrictive. The participant wanted schools to organise running, football or volleyball activities for families, particularly at weekends. The comment that “someone has to organise it” identifies a gap between available physical space and the organisational capacity required to turn that space into sustained family provision.

The fifth interview described another household constrained primarily by time and cost. The husband worked long hours, and Sunday was the only shared day, but it was also needed for rest. The family’s local park was poorly maintained, and a recently opened pool served only a small number of schools. This evidence shows that proximity alone does not guarantee access when public spaces are inadequately maintained or their use is restricted.

Together, the five interviews describe several forms of invisibility. Families may not receive information, their support needs may not be anticipated, or their working arrangements may not be reflected in schedules. Families affected by disability are formally permitted to participate but must repeatedly negotiate systems that were not designed with them in mind. Migrant and working families may live near potential venues but lack the information, organisation or suitable time needed to use them.

Greece’s Conclusion

Greece’s low participation rate is best understood as the outcome of several connected access failures. Families report not knowing what is available, being unable to attend at suitable times, travelling substantial distances and encountering

registration, parking or sensory conditions that make an activity difficult before it begins. These barriers are more intense for households facing financial pressure or disability-related needs. The interviews demonstrate that a family may be motivated and willing to participate while still being excluded by institutional arrangements.

The qualitative evidence also reveals an important difference between passive permission and active inclusion. Active inclusion requires organisations to anticipate how families receive information, register, travel, enter the venue, manage sensory conditions and seek assistance. It also requires regularity so that participants can become familiar with staff and surroundings. Schools, municipalities and neighbourhood facilities emerge as important potential connectors because they are already known to families. The opportunity identified by the Greek evidence is therefore an integrated local pathway combining systematic information, simple registration, accessible and sensory-aware delivery, workable timing, family participation and recurring opportunities rather than isolated events.

4.5 Spain

The Spain sample contains 40 survey responses and five interviews. It combines a clear preference for one-day entry events with a strong information barrier and a qualitative demand for sustained resources beyond one-off activity.

Indicator	Result	Interpretation
Participation	23 of 40 (57.5%)	Slightly above the five-country average
Financial difficulty	2 of 33 (6.1%)	Too small for subgroup interpretation
Migrant or minority background	5 of 33 (15.2%)	Small subgroup; findings require caution
Disability or support need	7 of 33 (21.2%)	Venue and coaching support remain relevant

Constraints and Participation Profile

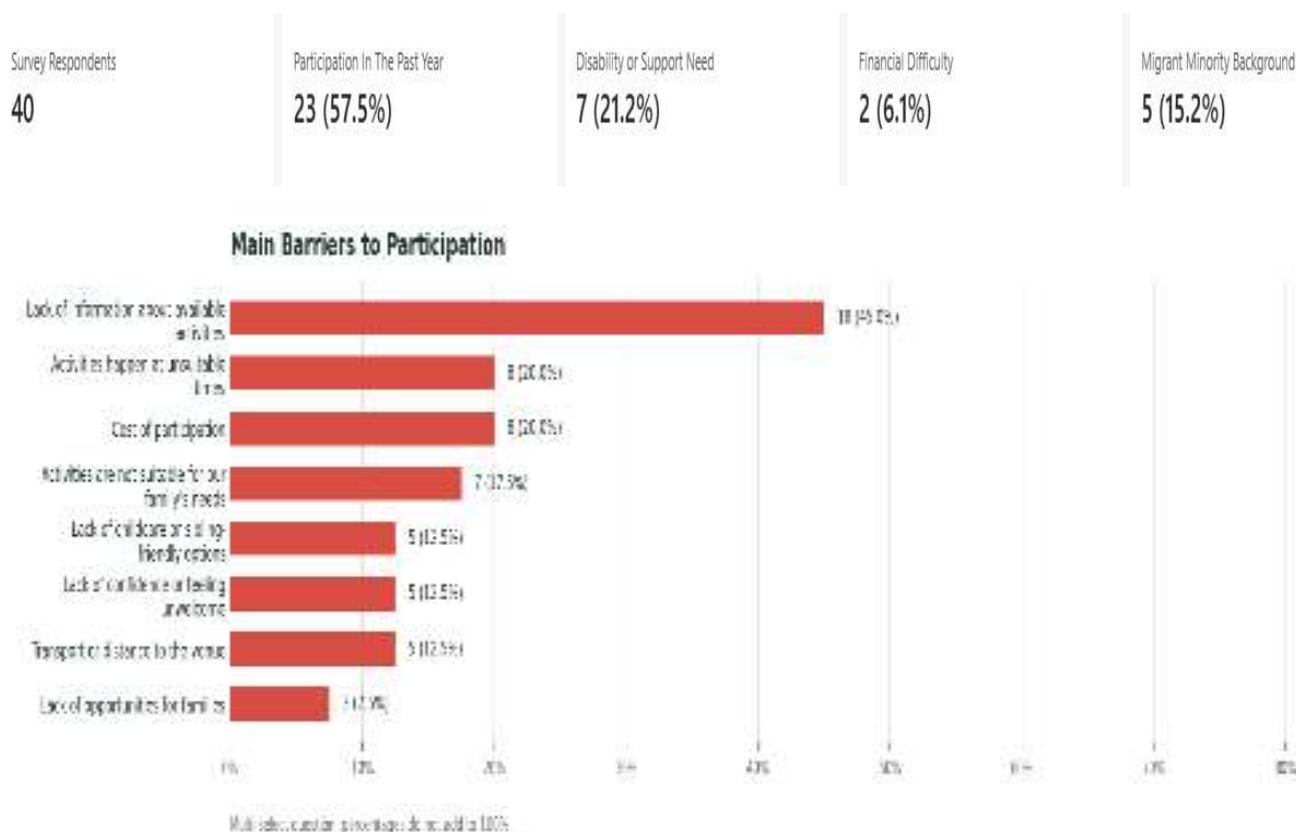


Figure 4.5.1 Spain participation profile and main barriers

Source: Spain survey, $n = 40$. Barrier percentages are multi-select.

Spain's participation rate was 57.5%, but lack of information was selected by 45.0%, more than twice the share selecting cost or unsuitable timing. This suggests that available provision and family awareness are poorly connected. Families may not know which activities are inclusive, whom they are for or how to access them.

Affordability and Cost Transparency

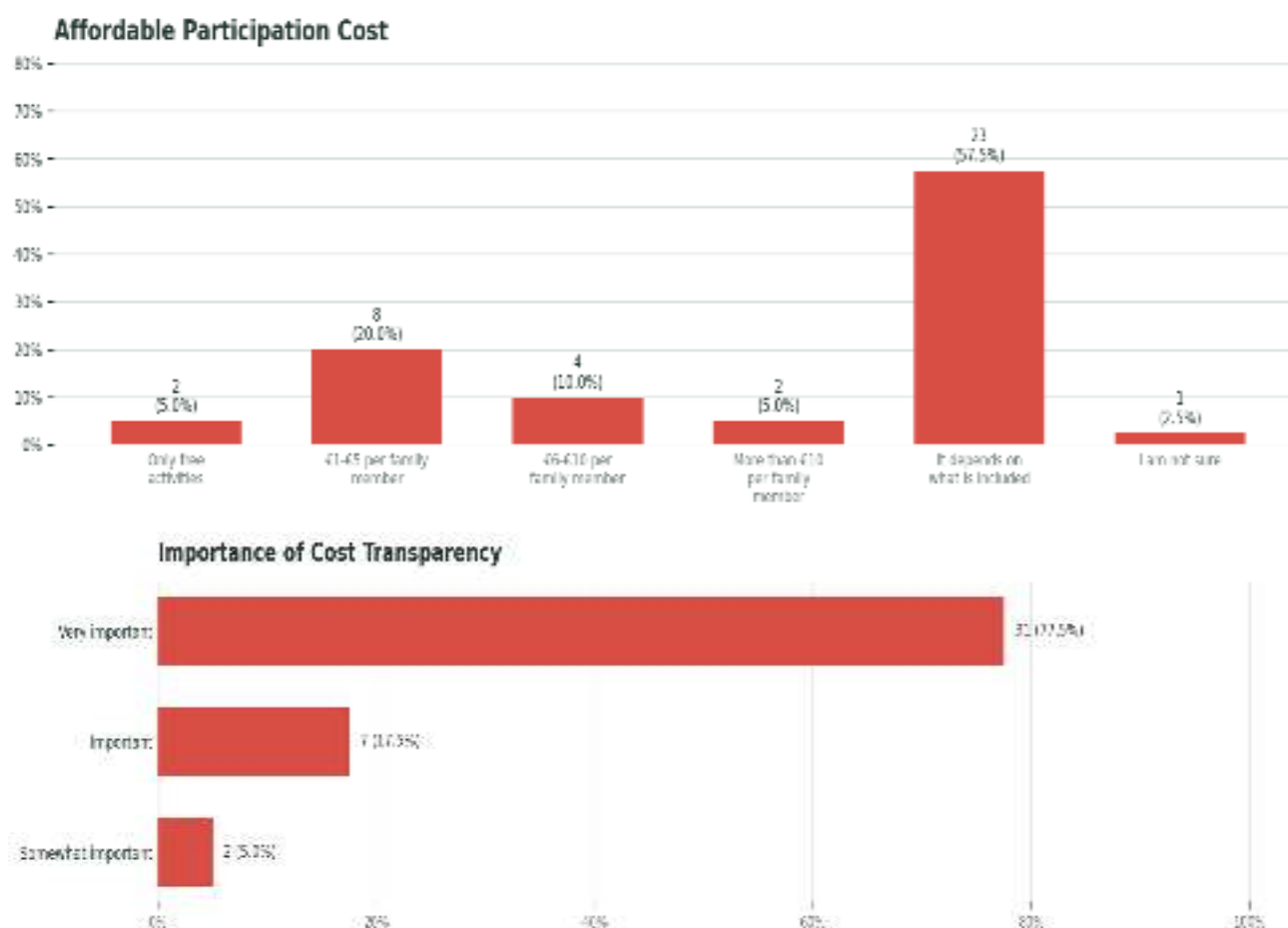


Figure 4.5.2 Spain affordability and cost transparency

Source: Spain survey, $n = 40$.

Cost remains important despite its lower ranking in the closed barrier question. A majority, 57.5%, said that affordability depended on what was included, while 95.0% considered cost transparency important or very important. Moreover, 30.3% of respondents answering the financial-difficulty question selected “Prefer not to say”. It would therefore be inappropriate to interpret the small recorded financial-difficulty subgroup as proof that affordability is unimportant.

Offer Design and Continuity

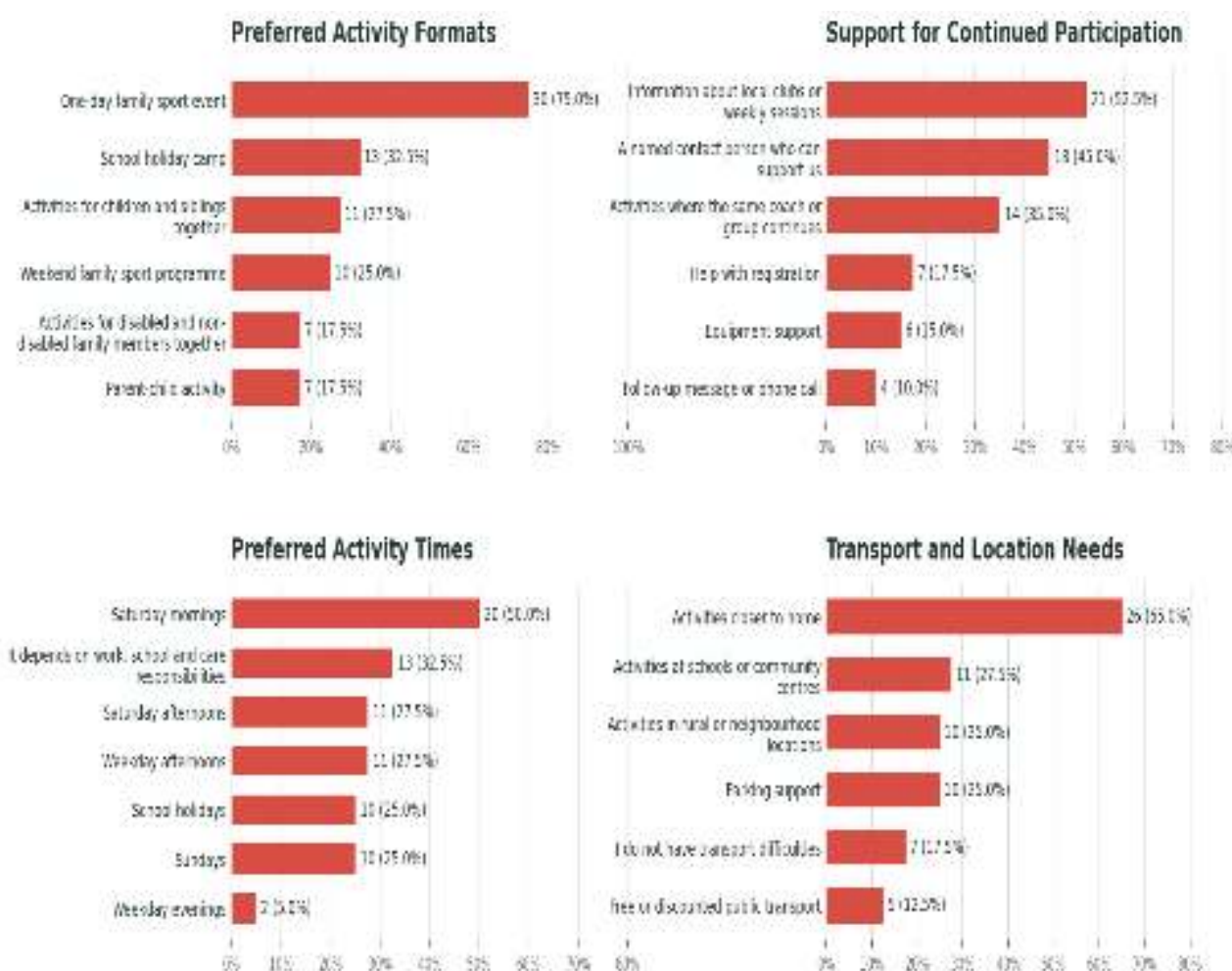


Figure 4.5.3 Spain preferred formats and continuation support

Source: Spain survey, $n = 40$. Both questions allowed up to three selections.

Spain's 75.0% preference for one-day events is the strongest programme-format result in the study. These events may reduce the perceived commitment and risk associated with trying an unfamiliar activity. However, local club information, a named contact and continuity with the same coach or group were also highly ranked. The findings support using events as entry points, not as the complete offer.

Saturday morning was the preferred time, selected by half the sample, while 65.0% wanted activities closer to home. This provides a clear practical entry model: local, low-threshold family opportunities delivered at a predictable weekend time, accompanied by information about what families can do afterwards.

One interview participant described the value of a funded family event because it allowed the family to discover games they could repeat independently. The same participant nevertheless stressed: "Provide more resources and facilitate access in the day to day. Not only one-off activities, but available resources sustained and prolonged in time".

Information Inclusion and Welcome

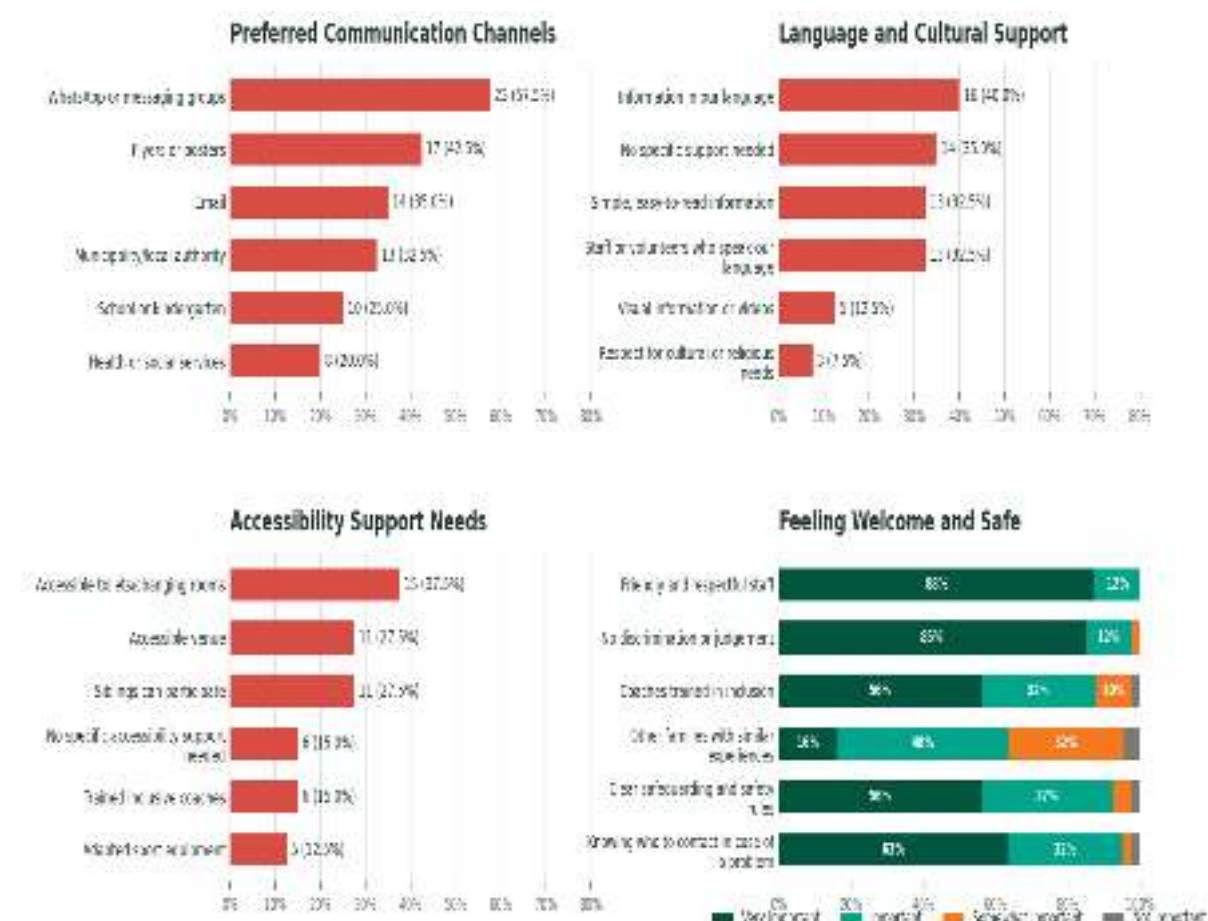


Figure 4.5.4 Spain communication language and accessibility priorities

Source: Spain survey, $n = 40$.

WhatsApp was the leading information channel at 57.5%, followed by flyers at 42.5% and email at 35.0%. Social media was selected by only 7.5%. General social-media promotion would therefore miss much of this sample. Direct messages, visible local material, municipalities, schools and services appear more appropriate.

Information in the family's language was selected by 40.0%, while accessible toilets or changing facilities were the leading accessibility support at 37.5%. Friendly staff were important or very important to all respondents. The combination indicates that inclusion is judged through concrete details and personal treatment, not through an organisation's general claim to be inclusive.

A Q15 respondent wrote: "Do not put inclusion as a luxury but as normality". An interview participant made the same distinction more critically: "Sport organisations love to talk about how 'inclusive' they are, but in practice there is a lot of practical work still to do; the gym I go to, for example, does not even have a ramp".

Family Perspectives from Q15 and Interviews

Among Spain's 33 substantive Q15 responses, affordability appeared in 15, welcome and accessibility in 11 each, information in seven and continuity in three. The open responses show that lack of information and financial uncertainty intersect with concerns about whether inclusion is genuine.

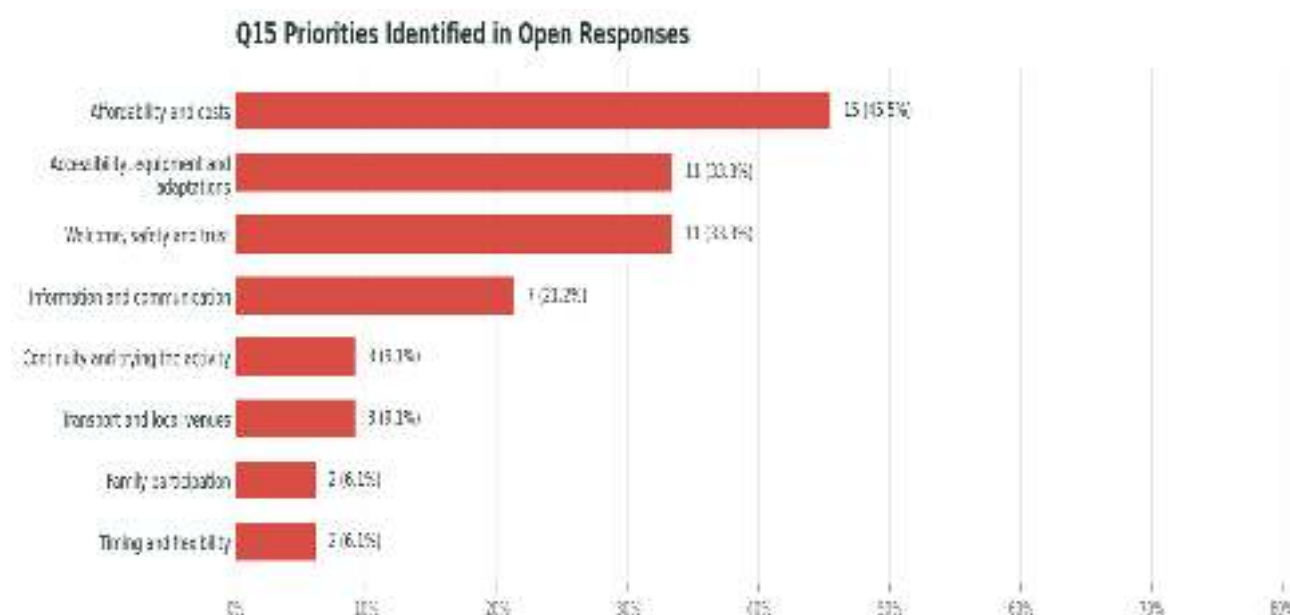


Figure 4.5.5 Spain Q15 themes and anonymised perspectives

Source: 33 substantive Q15 responses. Responses may carry several themes.

One respondent explained that social-media communication was insufficient because some disadvantaged or disabled families lived ordinary day-to-day lives without being connected to specialist information networks. The respondent proposed that municipalities and schools identify and inform families directly about suitable opportunities (S-Q15-37). Another called for **“real integration with people’s resources within regular local activities”**, rather than temporary or separate provision (S-Q15-21).

Several responses questioned symbolic uses of inclusion. One stated: **“Inclusion is always talked about, but in reality, many [activities] are not [inclusive]”** (S-Q15-19). Another asked organisations **not to present inclusion as a luxury but “as normality”** (S-Q15-34). These responses indicate that families judge inclusion through participation conditions, not through labels.

Themes Across Interviews

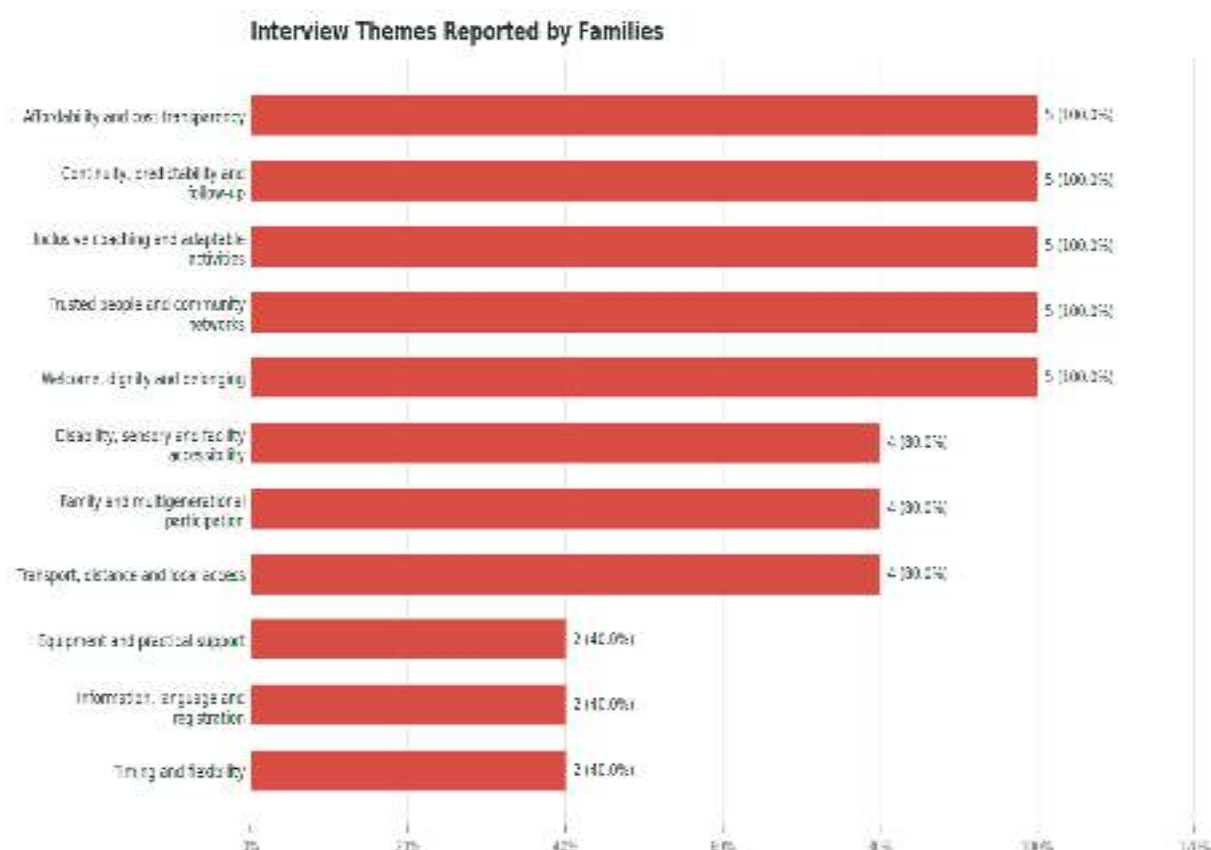


Figure 4.5.6 Spain interview themes

Source: Five interviews. Each interview may carry several themes.

The first interview emphasised equity and institutional relationships. The participant wanted organisations to be close to families, show genuine interest and treat people equitably. Past experiences strongly influenced whether the family would return. The participant proposed a dedicated bridge person in each club or association who could reach out to families, learn about their needs, communicate feedback to the organisation and explain available options. This proposed role addresses several barriers simultaneously. It would improve information, strengthen trust and give families a route through which to raise concerns without having to understand the full institutional structure. The participant also wanted cooperative, low-pressure activities in which people of different ages could participate.

The second interview described the role of community support. Attendance at a family event would not have been possible without help from the family's community. Safety and kindness were particularly important because the youngest child was shy and needed encouragement to build confidence and relationships. The participant described reorganising working hours around school and childcare, including working later at night. Cost and the shortage of affordable accessible spaces in Barcelona added to the pressure. The family found individual activities such as going to the gym less attractive than shared group activities: **"If there were more group activities available as a family, that would help us. This would encourage us and also motivate us as a family, to make it feel easier and more fun."** This account shows that family participation can itself be a motivational

support. The presence of relatives makes activity feel socially meaningful and reduces the pressure experienced by less-confident individuals.

The third interview criticised the competitive framing of sport. The participant argued that sport frequently became too serious and focused on performance and winning. Family activity should instead emphasise enjoyment, communication and cohesion. A safe environment without prejudice mattered more than perfect linguistic communication. The participant also described how culturally ordinary routines affected scheduling. An activity organised at 14:00 conflicted with the family's normal mealtime and need to rest afterwards. This example shows why timing cannot be defined as universally convenient without consulting families. Financial support for extracurricular sport was critical. The participant also called for partnerships with charities and organisations working with low-income families, migrants, people with disabilities, older people, LGBTQIA+ people and women affected by violence. Clubs should not assume that every family consisted of a mother, father and two children. The participant referred specifically to single-parent, same-sex, separated and multigenerational families and suggested opportunities in which grandparents could participate with grandchildren.

The fourth interview examined cost, transport, equipment and disability access. Walking and hiking might be free, but many locations were inaccessible without a car. Equipment made some sports unrealistic. Regular club participation could require an enrolment fee followed by monthly charges, and families restarting after an interruption might have to pay the enrolment fee again. The participant explained the consequence clearly: "It reaches a point where we have to end up prioritising; obviously paying for rent and food is more of a priority than sports." The same interview challenged superficial inclusion claims. The participant noted that a person with a lower-limb disability might be able to swim if a staff member helped them enter the pool, yet the participant's own gym lacked a ramp. The conclusion was that organisations needed to define what inclusion meant in practical terms and recognise that families' realities differed.

The fifth interview described the benefits of a fully funded family festival. The event allowed the family to discover enjoyable games that could later be repeated with relatives and friends. It therefore generated ideas and confidence rather than only providing activity on one day. However, the participant explicitly warned against relying on events alone: "Provide more resources and facilitate access in the day to day. Not only one-off activities, but available resources sustained and prolonged in time." The participant also observed that organised family events could bring together people who might not otherwise meet. This social value helps explain the survey preference for one-day events, but the account also clarifies that the event's value increases when it creates relationships, knowledge and opportunities that continue afterwards.

Spain's Conclusion

Spain's strong preference for one-day events should be interpreted as a preference for an approachable starting point, not for isolated provision. Families value fully

funded or low-pressure events because they lower commitment, allow different activities to be tried and create opportunities for social connection. However, the interviews and Q15 responses repeatedly ask what happens afterwards. Families need sustained local resources, affordable progression, direct communication and a trusted person who can bridge the distance between institutions and households. The qualitative evidence also expands the meaning of inclusion. It involves safe public space, accessible facilities, low-pressure coaching, flexible scheduling and recognition of diverse family structures. It also requires communication that reaches people outside specialist networks. Municipalities, schools, charities and community organisations may be important because they already know families whom general social-media campaigns fail to reach. Spain's central opportunity is therefore to use one-day events as deliberately connected entry points into regular local provision while embedding practical accessibility, family diversity and relationship-building into normal delivery.

5. Cross Country Trends, Challenges, and Opportunities for Intervention

The country findings show different points of failure within family participation. This section compares the trends, challenges and intervention opportunities identified by the survey and interview evidence, while preserving important differences between the five samples.

Participation Across the Five Samples

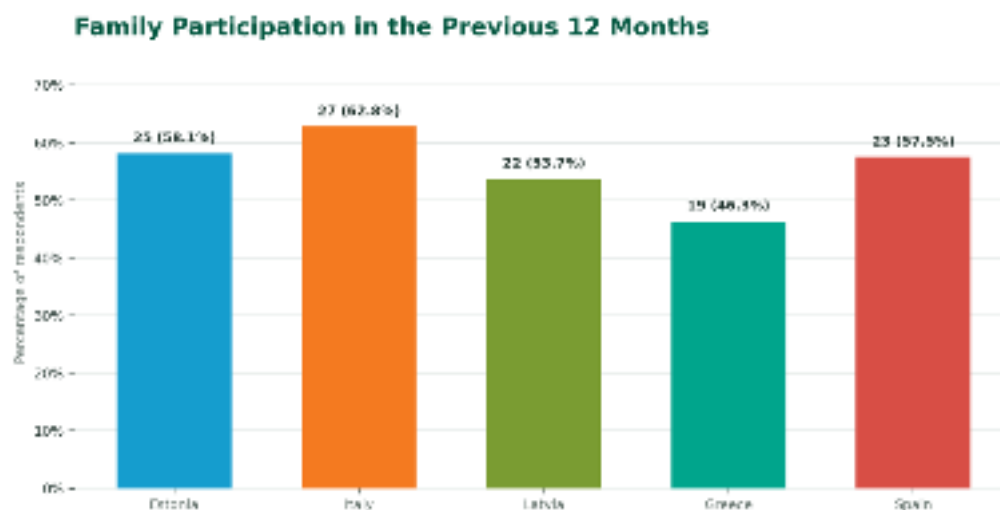


Figure 5a Recent family participation by country

Source: Five-country survey, n = 208. Percentages are calculated within country.

Across the five samples, 116 of 208 respondents, or 55.8%, reported family participation during the previous 12 months. Country participation ranged from 46.3% in Greece to 62.8% in Italy. These results demonstrate that participation already exists, but they do not show that access is easy or equitable. The interviews are particularly important in interpreting this finding. In Estonia, families described participating despite severe financial pressure, rural travel or sensory-access requirements. In Italy, children participated in competitive sport while parents

remained outside the experience. In Latvia, active families still struggled to locate regular and flexible opportunities. In Greece, families wanted to participate but could not find information or accessible local provision. In Spain, a funded event enabled participation that might otherwise have been unaffordable.

Participation is therefore not a binary condition. Families may attend once but lack a progression route; one child may participate while siblings and parents are excluded; or the household may remain involved only by absorbing substantial costs and logistical pressure. Analysis should consequently distinguish initial access, quality of experience and sustained participation.



Figure 5b. Leading participation constraints across the five countries

Source: Five-country survey, $n = 208$. Multi-select percentages use the country sample as denominator.

The principal cross-country challenge is that exclusion occurs at different stages. Estonia's problem is concentrated around affordability and subgroup support. Italy's concerns the family role and the organisation of facilities. Latvia's concerns scheduling and household logistics. Greece's concerns information and active enabling. Spain's concerns communication and the bridge between introductory events and sustained provision. A common framework is valuable, but its implementation must reflect where the participation journey is breaking down locally.

Opportunity indicated by the findings: The differences between the five samples point to a need for country-responsive approaches rather than a single uniform model. The evidence identifies where participation is currently interrupted in each setting, while decisions about the design and prioritisation of responses should be developed through the subsequent needs-assessment and framework-development work.

Affordability

Affordability emerges through every evidence source. Across the surveys, 38.9% said the acceptable cost depended on what was included, while another 37.5% selected free activity or no more than €5 per family member. Affordability appeared in 75 of 180 substantive Q15 responses and in 21 of 25 interviews.

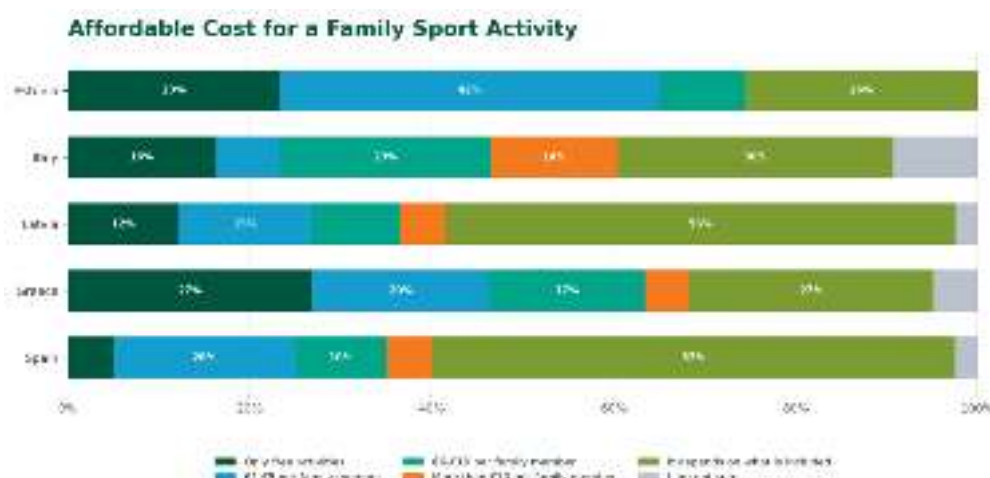


Figure 5c. Affordable cost preferences across all survey respondents

Source: Five-country survey, $n = 208$

The interviews explain that families calculate a total participation cost. The Estonia participant who listed shoes, a shirt, tournaments, transport and food demonstrated how a low advertised fee can conceal an unaffordable commitment. An Italian family declined a two-day tournament costing almost €300. The Latvian interviews showed how modest individual fees multiply across several children and how equipment must be replaced as children grow. In Spain, a participant described prioritising rent and food over club fees, while Greek participants connected fees to travel and the shortage of free local alternatives.

Financial difficulty also affects risk. Families may hesitate to purchase equipment before knowing whether a child will enjoy the activity. They may avoid seasonal membership if work or transport could interrupt attendance. Repeated registration fees can penalise families that need to pause and restart. A free introductory event reduces immediate cost but may create disappointment if the regular offer is subsequently unaffordable.

Dignity is equally important. The Estonia statement that “cheap does not have to feel like charity” should be treated as a major qualitative finding. Families may not use available support if claiming it requires public disclosure, complicated proof or repeated explanations of hardship. A formally available subsidy can therefore remain socially inaccessible.

Latvia is a major exception in relation to cost transparency. In Estonia, Italy, Greece and Spain combined, 151 of 167 respondents, or 90.4 %, considered advance explanation of the full cost important or very important. In Latvia, only one of 41 respondents, or 2.4 %, selected important, while none selected very important and 78.0 % selected not important. This divergence means that the all-country result

should not be presented as though the countries share one pattern. If Latvia is included without explanation, the pooled important-or-very-important proportion falls to 73.1 %. That figure conceals two contrasting results: overwhelming importance in four countries and very low stated importance in Latvia.

Latvia's answers also demonstrate that affordability and transparency are analytically distinct. More than one third of Latvian respondents identified cost as a barrier, and 56.1 % said an affordable amount depended on what was included. Respondents therefore cared about cost and value while placing little stated importance on receiving a comprehensive cost explanation before registration. The evidence cannot determine whether this reflects trust in familiar organisers, a preference for simple headline prices, an expectation that costs will be communicated routinely or a stronger focus on immediate practical constraints. Further qualitative exploration would be needed before selecting among these explanations.

Opportunity indicated by the findings: The results point to a need to consider affordability as the total cost of participation, including fees, equipment, transport and costs associated with accompanying children or siblings. Although advance cost transparency was highly valued in four country samples, Latvia presented a contrasting pattern, indicating that the relative importance and meaning of cost information should be interpreted within each national context.

These opportunities arise directly from the reported experiences. They do not imply that every programme must be free. They indicate that families require predictability, proportionality and the ability to test whether participation is sustainable.

Continuity and Follow Up

Continuity, predictability or follow-up appeared in every one of the 25 interviews. This is the clearest cross-country qualitative finding. Families repeatedly described the gap between an enjoyable first experience and the absence of a realistic next step.

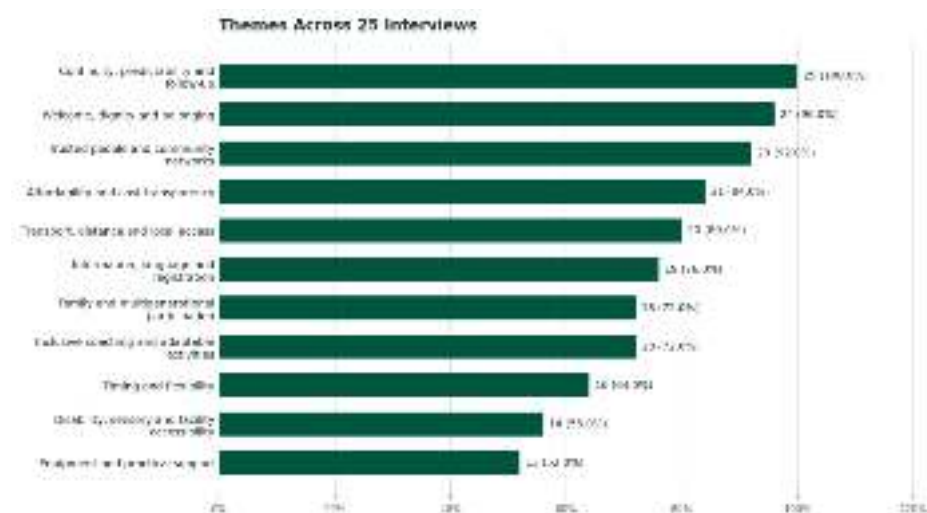


Figure 5d. Themes across all 25 interviews

Source: Five interviews per country, 25 in total. Interviews may carry several themes.

Continuity does not always mean weekly participation. Estonia favoured recurring weekly sessions, while some Latvian families preferred predictable monthly activities. Spain strongly favoured one-day events but wanted sustained resources afterwards. Greece wanted regular municipal events through which families could become familiar with staff and settings. Italy emphasised coaches, facilities and organisational stability. The interviews identify several continuity mechanisms. The next dates should be given before families leave. A follow-up message should explain the cost and what to bring. Familiar coaches and participants should remain involved. Families should be able to try the activity before purchasing equipment. Regular provision should remain close enough and at a suitable time. Support should not disappear when one trained member of staff is absent.

Continuity also depends on the relationship between introductory and regular provision. An event can generate confidence, social connections and knowledge of activities. It may even give families ideas they can repeat independently, as described in Spain. Its longer-term value is limited, however, when the regular offer is too expensive, distant or rigid.

Opportunity indicated by the findings: The qualitative evidence consistently identifies continuity, predictability and a clear next step as important to sustained participation. This suggests an opportunity to strengthen the connection between an initial activity and longer-term involvement, while the practical mechanisms for doing so should be considered in the later needs-assessment and framework-development stages.

Information and Language

Lack of information was the leading survey barrier in Greece and Spain and appeared in 61 substantive Q15 responses across the study. Nineteen interviews discussed information, language or registration. The qualitative accounts demonstrate that communication has at least four functions: helping families discover the activity, understand it, judge its suitability and act on the information.

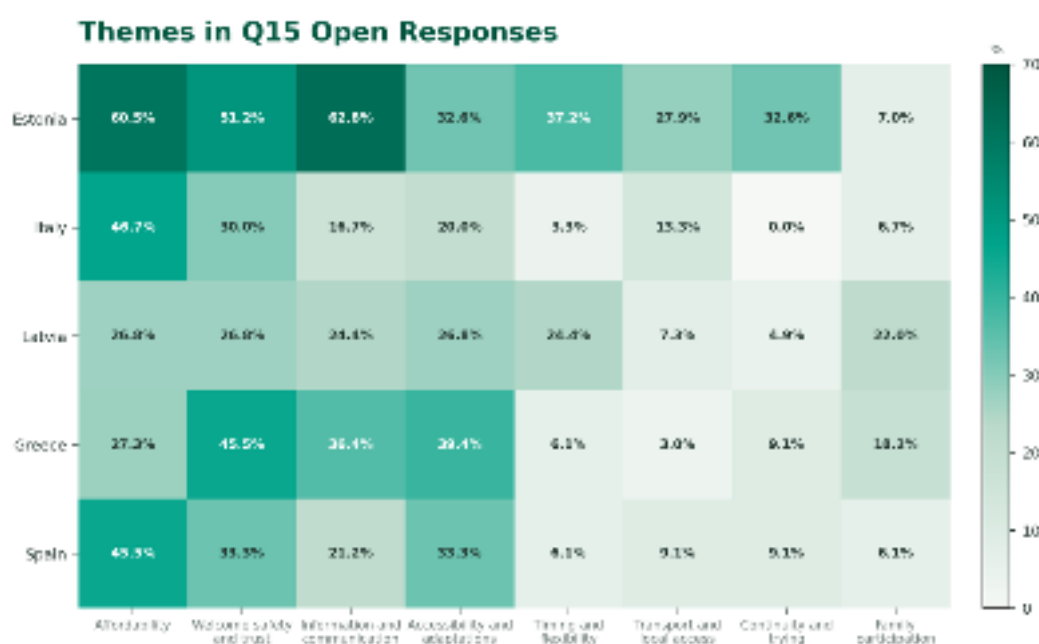


Figure 5e. Themes in Q15 open responses across the five countries

Source: 180 substantive Q15 responses. Responses may carry several themes.

Discovery depends on locally trusted channels. Estonia's migrant-family participant trusted a teacher, neighbour or another Ukrainian parent more than a polished advertisement. Greece's participants wanted systematic information through schools and municipalities. Spain proposed a bridge person and direct collaboration with schools, municipalities and charities. Latvia identified schools, social media and email, while also requesting much more complete practical information.

Understanding requires plain language, translation where necessary, visual demonstrations and patience. The Estonia participant's statement that language difficulty is not lack of ability is especially important. Families may understand their child's needs but lack confidence in expressing them. Communication practices should not infantilise adults or place migrant families into separate spaces unnecessarily. Suitability information includes cost, location, equipment, intensity, noise, group size, toilets, changing facilities, food, seating, sibling arrangements and accessibility. A family may decide not to attend because these details are missing, even when the activity itself would have been suitable.

Finally, information must lead to action. Complicated registration, advance collection of race materials or unclear eligibility can convert interest into non-participation. Greece provides the clearest example: families had to make additional journeys to collect registration numbers, while Estonia described registration involving several forms. Spain's bridge-role proposal responds to the same navigation problem.

Opportunity indicated by the findings: The results point to an opportunity to improve how families discover, understand and assess available activities. Information appears most effective when it is clear, accessible and communicated through locally trusted people or organisations, although the most appropriate channels and language support differ between countries and participant groups.

Accessibility and Adaptation

Disability and accessibility findings vary substantially between countries and subgroups, but the interviews reveal a common concern: organisations may describe themselves as inclusive while expecting families to perform most of the adaptation. The Greek statement that families were "just allowed to join" rather than enabled captures this distinction. Estonia's sensory-access interview showed that accessibility involved group size, noise, predictable structure and permission to take a break. Spain's interview contrasted claims of inclusion with a gym that lacked a ramp. Latvia's open responses extended accessibility to babies, pushchairs, changing facilities, quiet areas and seating.

The evidence also shows that inclusion does not necessarily require separation. Greek participants wanted disabled and non-disabled children to share spaces with suitable support. Estonia's migrant participant similarly rejected a separate "migrant

corner”. Families want access to ordinary community activity while retaining the adaptations necessary for meaningful participation.

Coaching is central because staff translate organisational commitments into lived experience. The Estonian coach who offered the choice to watch, listen or be shown demonstrated a simple adaptable practice. Greek respondents emphasised trained coaches and special-education knowledge. Spanish participants described practical assistance entering a pool. These examples show that inclusive coaching concerns observation, communication, flexibility and problem-solving, not only specialist certification.

Opportunity indicated by the findings: The findings indicate that accessibility should be understood as a combination of suitable venues, understandable information, appropriate equipment, adaptable activities and staff capacity. These needs are particularly important for families reporting disability or additional support requirements, even when they are less visible in the results for the full sample.

Welcome Safety and Belonging

Welcome, dignity or belonging appeared in 24 of 25 interviews, while trusted people and community networks appeared in 23. Across the comparable Q12 results, respectful staff, freedom from discrimination, safeguarding and knowing whom to contact received consistently high importance ratings.

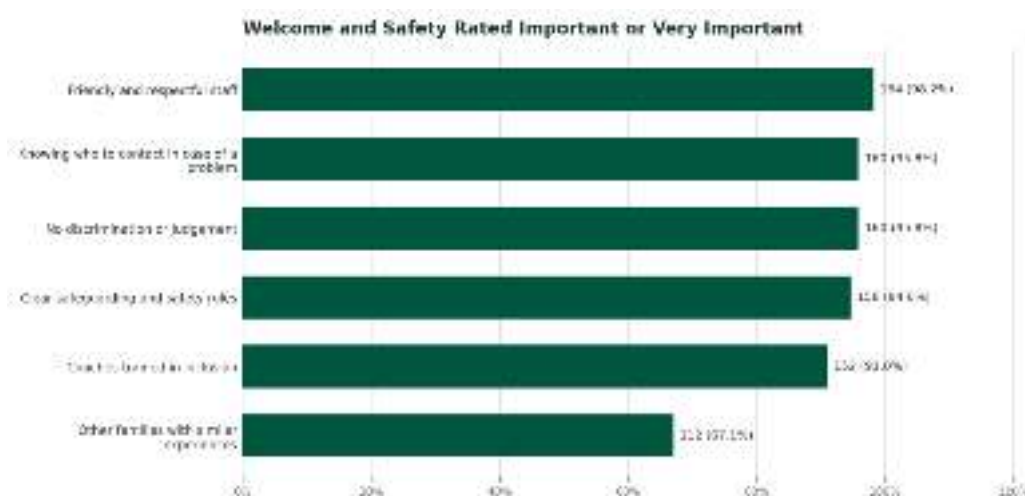


Figure 5f. Importance of welcome and safety conditions

Source: Estonia, Italy, Greece and Spain, n = 167. Shows Important plus Very Important.

The interviews reveal that these are not abstract values. Trust is created when a coach remembers a child's name, explains a rule without judgement, responds patiently to fear or adapts an exercise. It is damaged when a staff member sounds annoyed about a fee, when a parent feels that their family is disturbing others or when an organisation claims inclusion without practical preparation. Previous experience has a cumulative effect. Spain's interviews emphasised that a positive or negative experience strongly influenced whether the family returned. Greece described a child leaving a loud event and never returning. Estonia described

families stopping when every week felt like beginning again with different people and instructions.

Competitive culture can also affect belonging. Spain and Latvia both contained calls for lower-pressure, cooperative activity. Estonia's multigenerational family avoided disguised competitions because grandparents and less-confident adults stepped back. This does not mean competition is inherently exclusionary. It means families need a choice between competitive progression and recreational participation based on connection, movement and enjoyment.

Latvia represents a genuine exception to the otherwise strong cross-country emphasis on welcome and safety. In Estonia, Italy, Greece and Spain combined, 98.2 % rated friendly and respectful staff as important or very important. The corresponding Latvian figure was zero. Freedom from discrimination or judgement was important or very important to 95.8 % across the other four countries, compared with 2.4 % in Latvia.

The contrast continues across the remaining conditions. Trained inclusive coaches were important or very important to 91.0 % in the other four samples and 19.5 % in Latvia. Clear safeguarding was important or very important to 94.6 % in the other countries and 9.8 % in Latvia. Knowing whom to contact was important or very important to 95.8 % elsewhere and 7.3 % in Latvia.

The difference was smaller for the presence of families with similar experiences. This was important or very important to 67.1 % across Estonia, Italy, Greece and Spain and to 43.9 % in Latvia. It was also the highest-rated Q12 condition within Latvia. The relative prominence of peer familiarity suggests that social reassurance may be more meaningful to Latvian respondents when it is embodied by other families rather than expressed through formal organisational commitments. This finding must be interpreted carefully. It does not demonstrate that Latvian respondents prefer unsafe or disrespectful environments. It demonstrates that the listed conditions were generally not reported as important factors in their participation decision. Families may regard them as baseline expectations, may prioritise immediate practical considerations, or may understand belonging primarily through familiar community relationships. The qualitative evidence complicates the picture further. Welcome and belonging appeared in all five Latvian interviews, while Q15 responses referred to non-judgemental activity, friendly coaches, community and families feeling connected. Latvia therefore provides the strongest example of divergence between a structured scale and qualitative evidence. The scale captures the low stated importance of formal conditions; the interviews capture how friendliness, familiarity and community affect the lived experience.

Opportunity indicated by the findings: The evidence identifies respectful treatment, freedom from judgement and the presence of trusted people as important dimensions of participation. Latvia's closed-question results differed substantially from those of the other countries, while its qualitative evidence continued to emphasise relationships, familiarity and belonging; this suggests that

welcome may be understood and expressed differently across national and methodological contexts.

Infrastructure, Timing, and Logistics

Timing was the leading barrier in Latvia and an important issue in every country's interviews. The qualitative evidence shows that "time" includes paid work, shift patterns, school hours, care duties, meals, rest, several children's activities and the time required to travel and register.

The Italian shift-working parent described activities designed around standard office hours. A Greek family could participate together only on Sundays, which was also its only day for rest. A Latvian family described feeding and preparing several children before travel. The Estonian rural family's transport burden began before the activity and continued through fuel cost, winter conditions and the absence of a suitable return bus. Transport should therefore not be measured only in kilometres. It includes whether a household owns a car, whether public transport operates after the session, whether parking is available, whether a parent can leave work, and whether several children must be taken to different locations. Italy's interviews show how families with cars and flexible work can compensate for fragmented facilities, while less-resourced families cannot.

Local delivery was the most consistent practical facilitator: 64.4 % of all respondents selected activities closer to home. Schools and community centres were also prominent because they are familiar, geographically distributed and already connected to family routines. However, the Italian evidence cautions that the existence of a school gym does not guarantee access when it is unavailable at weekends, poorly maintained or governed by unstable agreements.

Opportunity indicated by the findings: The evidence identifies proximity, workable scheduling and manageable household logistics as connected conditions of access. Opportunities therefore exist to make participation more compatible with families' work, school, care and travel circumstances, while the specific arrangements required should be determined within each country context. The evidence suggests that flexibility should not mean unpredictability. Families need a stable rhythm and advance information, but they may require several ways to participate within that structure.

Family Roles Structures and Shared Participation

The interviews demonstrate that the term "family sport" requires more careful definition. In some activities, children participate while parents pay, organise transport and watch. In others, parents, siblings and grandparents take part directly. Some families want to be active together; others need flexible roles because of age, disability, confidence or care responsibilities.

Italy provides the clearest critique of parents as fee-payers rather than participants. Estonia's description of parents becoming "coat racks" at a family event conveys the same problem. Latvia showed how limiting an activity to one child forces larger families to choose who receives the opportunity. Spain highlighted single-parent,

same-sex, separated and multigenerational households. Greece's migrant interviews showed how long working hours can leave only one possible shared day.

Family participation may itself support continuity. Parents can model activity, children can motivate adults, siblings can reduce anxiety and grandparents can provide transport or care. Conversely, designing the activity around one individual can increase the practical burden on everyone else.

Opportunity indicated by the findings: The survey and interview evidence points to opportunities for forms of participation that recognise the family as a household rather than focusing exclusively on one child or individual participant. The importance of parents, siblings, grandparents and other carers varies across families, so the appropriate form of family involvement should remain adaptable rather than being defined through one fixed model.

Continuity from First Contact to Last Participation

Continuity, predictability or follow-up appeared in every one of the 25 interviews. This is the clearest cross-country qualitative finding. Families repeatedly described the gap between an enjoyable first experience and the absence of a realistic next step.

Continuity does not always mean weekly participation. Estonia favoured recurring weekly sessions, while some Latvian families preferred predictable monthly activities. Spain strongly favoured one-day events but wanted sustained resources afterwards. Greece wanted regular municipal events through which families could become familiar with staff and settings. Italy emphasised coaches, facilities and organisational stability.

The interviews identify several continuity mechanisms. The next dates should be given before families leave. A follow-up message should explain the cost and what to bring. Familiar coaches and participants should remain involved. Families should be able to try the activity before purchasing equipment. Regular provision should remain close enough and at a suitable time. Support should not disappear when one trained member of staff is absent.

Continuity also depends on the relationship between introductory and regular provision. An event can generate confidence, social connections and knowledge of activities. It may even give families ideas they can repeat independently, as described in Spain. Its longer-term value is limited, however, when the regular offer is too expensive, distant or rigid.

Opportunity indicated by the findings: The qualitative evidence consistently identifies continuity, predictability and a clear next step as important to sustained participation. This suggests an opportunity to strengthen the connection between an initial activity and longer-term involvement, while the practical mechanisms for doing so should be considered in the later needs-assessment and framework-development stages.

Cross – Country Interpretation Conclusion

The quantitative results identify which barriers are most frequently selected, but the qualitative evidence explains what those barriers mean. “Cost” includes hidden charges, equipment, travel and financial risk. “Timing” includes shift work, school, care, meals and rest. “Transport” includes fuel, parking, public-transport schedules and the availability of a parent. “Information” includes trust, translation, registration and knowing whether a child will genuinely be accepted. “Accessibility” includes sensory conditions, toilets, staff capacity and the ability to take a break without apologising.

The interviews also demonstrate substantial family agency. Participants are not passive recipients waiting for organisations to solve every problem. Families share rides, translate for one another, organise informal parent events, adapt games, use parks, support children through fear and create community networks. The challenge is that they are often required to compensate for systems that are fragmented, inflexible or unclear. Intervention opportunities should build on these family and community resources without transferring all responsibility back to families.

Across the five countries, an inclusive participation pathway can be understood as a connected sequence. Families first need to hear about an opportunity through a trusted source. They then need sufficient information to assess cost, timing, suitability and accessibility. They must be able to organise and reach the venue. On arrival, they need respectful staff, understandable instructions and appropriate adaptation. Finally, they need a realistic next step. If any link fails, the family may not attend or may participate once without continuing.

Latvia also demonstrates the importance of preserving country differences instead of relying only on pooled averages. On cost transparency and five of the six welcome-and-safety conditions, Latvian respondents answered in the opposite direction from the other four samples. Pooling these responses would create moderate-looking overall percentages that accurately describe none of the underlying country patterns.

The Latvian findings also demonstrate the value of the mixed-methods design. The quantitative scale indicates that formal welcome and safety conditions were rarely decisive, whereas the interviews describe community, friendliness, familiar people and belonging as meaningful. Neither source should cancel the other. Together they suggest that respondents may distinguish between abstract organisational criteria and welcome as it is experienced through relationships.

This observation strengthens the wider cross-country conclusion that inclusive family sport cannot be communicated identically in every context. The core responsibilities of affordability, safety, respectful treatment and accessibility remain common, but the factors that families consciously prioritise and the language through which they recognise those conditions can differ. In Latvia, practical usability and peer familiarity appear more prominent than formal advance assurances.

The strongest conclusion from the combined evidence is therefore that inclusion cannot be delivered by a single feature. A free event can remain inaccessible because of transport. An accessible venue can remain unused because information does not reach families. A welcoming coach cannot provide continuity if the facility is unavailable. A one-day event cannot produce sustained engagement when the regular programme is unaffordable. Effective intervention requires these conditions to be considered together from the perspective of the entire family.

6. Conclusion

The combined survey and interview evidence shows that access to family sport cannot be understood as a simple distinction between participation and non-participation. Across the five partner samples, 116 of 208 respondents, or 55.8%, reported that their family had participated in a relevant activity during the previous 12 months. However, participation frequently occurred alongside substantial financial, logistical, informational or accessibility pressures. Families may attend an activity once without being able to continue, maintain one child's participation by making sacrifices elsewhere, or remain involved only through significant efforts to coordinate work, care, transport and household finances. The central conclusion of this report is therefore that meaningful access involves the whole participation journey: discovering an opportunity, understanding what it involves, deciding whether it is affordable and suitable, organising attendance, reaching and using the venue, feeling accepted during the activity and having a realistic route into continued participation.

The country findings demonstrate why a single explanation for exclusion would be inadequate. Estonia combined an above-average participation rate with the study's most concentrated affordability problem: 76.7% selected cost as a barrier and the same proportion reported financial difficulty. Italy recorded the highest participation rate, at 62.8%, but its leading barrier was the shortage of opportunities designed for families, supported by interview accounts in which parents were treated principally as payers, drivers and spectators rather than participants. Latvia's most prominent issue was unsuitable timing, selected by 56.1%, and its qualitative evidence exposed the planning burden experienced by larger and more varied households. Greece recorded the lowest participation rate, at 46.3%, together with strong information, transport and accessibility barriers. Spain combined a clear preference for one-day introductory events with a strong demand for sustained resources and a visible next step. These differences show that exclusion occurs at different stages of the participation journey and that pooled results must not obscure the specific circumstances reported in each country.

Affordability nevertheless remains an important common thread. Across the five samples, 38.9% said that an acceptable fee depended on what was included, while a further 37.5% selected free participation or no more than €5 per family member. Affordability was also the most frequent Q15 theme, appearing in 75 of 180 substantive responses, and was discussed in 21 of the 25 interviews. The qualitative accounts show that families assess the complete financial commitment rather than

the advertised fee alone. Equipment, clothing, transport, food, childcare, sibling participation, competitions and repeated registration charges can transform a modest price into an unmanageable commitment. Financial uncertainty also increases the risk attached to trying an unfamiliar activity. At the same time, the statement that “cheap does not have to feel like charity” captures an important finding: affordability is connected to dignity, and support may fail to promote participation if families feel publicly identified, judged or required to repeatedly justify their circumstances.

Practical access extends beyond cost. Nearly two thirds of respondents preferred activities closer to home, while the interviews demonstrated that distance must be understood through travel time, fuel, parking, public-transport schedules and the availability of an adult to accompany children. Timing similarly encompasses shift work, school hours, meals, rest, caring responsibilities and the competing needs of several family members. Information determines whether families can evaluate all these factors. Greece and Spain identified lack of information as their leading barrier, while families across the countries asked for clear details about price, location, registration, equipment, intensity, accessibility and whom to contact. Trusted communication was often more influential than general promotion: families referred to schools, municipalities, coaches, community organisations, other parents and personal messaging as credible routes into participation. Language support was most effective when it enabled families to enter ordinary activities confidently rather than separating them from the wider community.

The evidence also demonstrates the difference between being permitted to attend and being substantively included. Families described inaccessible toilets and changing facilities, unsuitable registration processes, sensory overload, lack of ramps, limited staff understanding and uncertainty about whether additional needs would be accommodated. The Greek observation that some families were “just allowed to join” rather than enabled to participate captures this distinction. Accessibility involves the venue, information, equipment, activity design and staff response operating together. Welcome and belonging are similarly practical experiences. They are created when staff communicate patiently, remember participants, respond without judgement and adapt an activity appropriately. Latvia provides an important qualification: its respondents placed little stated importance on formal cost-transparency and welcome-and-safety criteria, yet its Q15 responses and interviews continued to emphasise familiar people, friendliness, community and belonging. This divergence confirms the value of combining structured survey results with qualitative evidence and cautions against assuming that the same concept will be understood or expressed identically in every context.

The 25 interviews provide the clearest evidence that continuity is central to family participation. Predictability, follow-up or a route into continued activity appeared in every interview; welcome, dignity or belonging appeared in 24; and trusted people or community networks appeared in 23. Families did not necessarily request identical schedules or programme formats. Estonia showed stronger demand for weekly sessions, some Latvian families preferred a regular monthly rhythm, and Spain strongly favoured one-day events. What families shared was the need to know what would happen next and whether continued participation would remain

affordable, local, suitable and supported. The interviews also show that families are active contributors rather than passive recipients. They share transport, translate for one another, adapt games, support children through fear and create informal community networks. However, they are frequently required to compensate for fragmented systems. Family-friendly provision must therefore be understood from the perspective of the whole household, including parents, carers, siblings, grandparents and diverse family structures, rather than assuming that access for one child represents access for the family.

These findings should be interpreted as descriptive evidence from the five partner samples, not as national population estimates. The country samples were small and were not selected through documented national probability-sampling procedures. Recruitment context, missing background data, translation and differences in how some questions were recorded may also have influenced the results. Nevertheless, the repeated convergence between the closed survey questions, 180 substantive Q15 responses and 25 interviews gives the findings considerable explanatory value. Where the evidence diverges, as in Latvia, that divergence is itself informative because it reveals differences between formal ratings and lived experience. The report therefore provides a credible account of where participation becomes difficult for the families consulted, how barriers combine and which conditions they associate with usable and sustainable opportunities.

Overall, D2.1 identifies a connected set of intervention opportunities around affordability, local access, workable timing, clear and trusted information, meaningful accessibility, respectful participation, family-appropriate formats and continuity beyond an initial event. These are evidence-based directions emerging from families' experiences rather than detailed prescriptions for programme delivery. Decisions concerning priorities, implementation mechanisms, organisational responsibilities and the design of specific interventions should be developed through the subsequent needs-assessment and framework-development work. The contribution of this report is to establish the empirical foundation for that next stage: socially at-risk families are more likely to participate and continue when the entire pathway is understandable, financially realistic, practically manageable, inclusive in everyday delivery and connected to a dependable next opportunity.

7. Sources

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Primary project sources reviewed for this report:

- Move, Play & Belong family-focused activity and interview questionnaire.
- Estonia Power BI report and MPB Power BI Ready Survey Data Aug 2026 with Q15 and Interview Coding.xlsx.
- Italy Power BI report and MPB Italy Power BI Ready Survey and Interview Data 2026.xlsx.
- Latvia Power BI report and MPB Latvia Power BI Ready Survey and Interview Data 2026.xlsx.
- Greece Power BI report and Power BI ready survey and interview dataset.
- Spain Power BI report and Power BI ready survey and interview dataset.

8. Appendix

A. Questionnaire and Analytical Treatment

Question	Topic	Response Type	Treatment in This Report
Q1	Recent participation family	Single choice	Count and percentage within country
Q2	Main barriers	Multi-select up to three	Share selecting each barrier
Q3	Affordable amount	Single choice	Distribution of price preferences
Q4	Cost transparency	Single choice	Important plus Very Important; Latvia excluded pending coding check
Q5	Preferred programme format	Multi-select up to three	Share selecting each format
Q6	Continuation support	Multi-select up to three	Share selecting each support as a top-three priority
Q7	Timing	Country datasets vary	Share selecting each timing option; Greece undefined code flagged

Q8	Transport and location	Multi-select	Share selecting each factor
Q9	Communication	Multi-select up to three	Share selecting each channel
Q10	Language and cultural inclusion	Multi-select	Share selecting each support
Q11	Accessibility	Multi-select	Overall and selected subgroup interpretation
Q12	Welcome and safety	Six-item Likert scale	Important plus Very Important; Latvia excluded; Spain caveat applied
Q13	Family role	Mostly single choice	Country result; Spain not pooled because recorded as multi-select
Q14	Feedback	Single choice	Definite feedback routes and Maybe
Q15	What organisations should do differently	Open text	Multi-theme qualitative coding
Q16	Optional background	Mixed	Descriptive and subgroup use subject to missingness and minimum cell size

B. Data Quality and Interpretation Notes

- The survey and interview samples were recruited by project partners and should not be interpreted as nationally representative.
- Multi-select percentages do not sum to 100 % because a respondent may select several options.
- Q15 and interview theme counts are also non-exclusive. Coding records each meaningful theme present in an answer.
- Spain contains multiple ratings for some Q12 statements and records Q13 and Q16c as multi-select. These items are described with explicit caveats rather than forced into a common structure.
- Optional background completion varies. Latvia did not populate Q16c to Q16f; Italy and Spain have partial completion. Denominators are stated when they differ from the full country sample.
- Open-text excerpts are short and anonymised. Identifying combinations of location and personal background are not reproduced.
- The Power BI figures are static high-resolution reproductions based on the submitted PBIX report definitions and decoded source data. They are designed for PDF reading and do not rely on interactive tooltips.